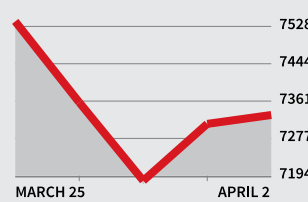


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 73319.55 (-1953.90)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	22713.10	-593.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.15	-0.54
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.10	-0.87
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	146021.00	+401
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	227813.00	-7001

POLLSCAPE.

BJP releases candidates list for Tamil Nadu, excludes Annamalai; says contest between the NDA and the DMK, downplays Vijay's party **p5**



AUTO FOCUS.

Renault Duster returns strong, but faces stiff competition in the crowded SUV segment **p4**

QUICKLY.

SEDAN STEALS SHOW
Maruti Suzuki's Dzire tops PV sales in FY26



New Delhi: Despite the dominating market shift towards sport utility vehicles, Maruti Suzuki's Dzire sedan reclaimed the throne as India's best-selling passenger vehicle for FY26. The Dzire led the pack with approximately 2.3 lakh units sold, proving that the sedan segment still holds significant weight in the Indian market. **p2**

STOCKING UP
Central banks' net gold purchases up in February

Chennai: Gold purchases by central banks in February were led by the National Bank of Poland (NBP) and Uzbekistan, but Türkiye and Russia turned sellers, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) showed. Central banks were net buyers of 19 tonnes, driven largely by a 20-tonne purchase by NBP. The Polish central bank resumed buying after a lull in January. This was its highest purchase after February 2025, when it bought 29 tonnes. **p8**

Russia offers India top up of crude, fertilizers and LNG

'STRAITENED'. Hormuz disruption pushes Delhi to up reliance on Moscow energy supplies

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Russia has offered to step up energy trade with India by supplying more crude oil and fertilizers at a time when the world's third-largest energy consumer is exploring alternatives to meet the oil and gas deficit created by the West Asia conflict.

Moscow also offered liquefied natural gas (LNG) even as India is scouting for cargoes from the US and Australia, as the closure of the Strait of Hormuz has impacted 47 per cent of its LNG imports.

SUPPLY BOOST

First Deputy Prime Minister of Russia Denis Manturov said on Friday that Russian companies had the capacity to steadily increase supplies of oil and LNG to India. Manturov noted that by the end of 2025, Russia had increased supplies of in-demand mineral fertilizers to India by 40 per cent and is ready to continue meeting India's demand for this product.



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DENIS MANTUROV
First Deputy Prime Minister of Russia



In addition, a joint project for carbamide production is under development.

"Particular attention was paid to cooperation in the oil and gas sector. Denis Manturov confirmed that Russian companies have the capacity to steadily increase supplies of oil and liquefied natural gas to the Indian market," said a Russian Embassy statement.

MEETS PM, MINISTERS

Manturov, who is on a two-day official visit to India, met top Ministers and officials,

including Foreign Minister S Jaishankar, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. Manturov called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday and held discussions.

Particular attention was paid to cooperation in the oil and gas sector.

The discussions also covered areas such as industrial cooperation, space and education, the Embassy statement said.

"Expanding mutually beneficial trade, investment

and industrial cooperation ties was one of the key topics on the agenda. Specific steps were discussed to create favourable conditions for increasing bilateral trade turnover in the present context," it noted.

OMCS BUY RUSSIA OIL

Meanwhile, Indian refiners have shifted back to Russian crude oil, buying around 60 million barrels from Moscow since March 5 as closure of the Strait of Hormuz impacted 40 per cent of its imports, according to the Oxford Institute for Energy Studies (OIES).

In a first, India is buying Russian crude (at sea) at a premium, which sources said had hit a high of \$8-9 per barrel. Besides, Russia is also supplying LPG to India.

OIES, in its recent energy comment, pointed out that the scale of the Hormuz disruption was like "no other seen in oil market history".

In such a scenario, one of the US tools to help put a lid on crude prices has been granting exemptions on sanctioned barrels. Russia has been a clear beneficiary of this measure.

Domestic airfares jump 44% despite govt's relief measures, fuel levy bites

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Domestic airfares have surged sharply despite a series of relief measures by the Centre, with average ticket prices up 44 per cent year-on-year in April.

Cleartrip data showed the average domestic ticket price had risen from ₹5,850 in April 2025 to ₹8,450 this month.

International airfares have risen by 43 per cent over the same period, with average ticket prices increasing from ₹52,000 to ₹74,500 over the same period.

Another dataset from Wego India also indicated a rising trend in domestic fares.

The average domestic booking values this month are in the range of ₹9,000-10,000, compared to ₹8,500-9,500 in 2025, reflecting a 12 per cent year-on-year increase.

RELIEF MEASURES

The fare increases come even as the Ministry of Civil Aviation implemented multiple measures to ease the cost pressure on airlines, including removing fare caps and keeping the 60 per cent free seat allocation rule in



SKY HIGH. International airfares have risen about 43%, with average ticket prices climbing from ₹52,000 in April 2025 to ₹74,500

abeyance. Additionally, a rebate on aviation turbine fuel (ATF) has also been provided.

According to sources, these relief measures were aimed at cushioning airlines against a sharp rise in operating costs, driven by higher ATF prices, airspace restrictions, and currency pressures. In the absence of such interventions, airlines may have been forced to undertake steeper fare increases, reduce capacity and rationalise routes to maintain financial viability.

However, a fuel surcharge and fewer flights in the summer schedule continue to push domestic airfares higher.

FARE GAP

Notably, spot fares across key metro routes are significantly higher than advance

purchase levels. On the Delhi-Bengaluru route, fares range between ₹10,500 and ₹14,000 for immediate travel against ₹7,200-₹8,500 for bookings made 15 days in advance. On the Mumbai-Chennai sector, the fares stand at ₹8,200-10,500 and ₹4,400-₹5,200 respectively.

On the Mumbai-Delhi sector, spot fares range between ₹9,500 and ₹12,800, while advance fares are ₹5,800 and ₹7,100. Bengaluru-Mumbai fares are currently between ₹8,400 and ₹11,200, compared to ₹4,900-₹6,300 for 15-day advance bookings.

A similar trend is seen on metro to non-metro routes as well. Delhi-Varanasi fares range between ₹10,500 and ₹14,500 for near-term travel, compared to ₹4,600-₹5,500 for advance bookings.

Iranian crude tanker headed to India diverts to China 'over payment terms issue'

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

An Aframax tanker carrying around 6,00,000 barrels of Iranian crude from Kharg Island, which was en route to Vadinar (Gujarat), has now changed course towards China. This would have been the first Iranian crude cargo delivered to India since May 2019. Amid the West Asia conflict and the ensuing oil price volatility, the US administration temporarily lifted sanctions for over 30 days on Iranian oil on water, loaded before March 20, opening access for India to these once sanctioned barrels.

Global real-time data and analytics provider Kpler said the Iranian crude vessel, *Ping Shun*, earlier bound for

Mid-voyage destination changes highlight the growing sensitivity of trade flows to financial terms and counterparty risk

Vadinar, over the past three days has dropped India as its declared destination and is now signalling China.

TIGHTER TERMS

"Per market sources, the shift appears to be payment-related, with sellers tightening terms, moving away from the earlier 30/60-day credit window towards upfront or near-term settlement," said Sumit Ritolia,

Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining and Modeling. Ritolia suggested that the ship changed course near the finish line because the seller demanded immediate payment instead of the usual credit terms.

While such mid-voyage destination changes are not unprecedented with Iranian crude, they highlight the growing sensitivity of trade flows to financial terms and counterparty risk.

Ritolia added that if the payment issues are resolved, the cargo could still reach an Indian refinery.

The episode highlights how commercial terms are now as critical as logistics in determining Iranian crude flows beyond China, he added.

Vortexa, in its March 2026 crude report, said the US

waiver on Iranian and Russian oil offers temporary relief. It also pointed to "payment issues" related to Iranian cargoes.

"The US easing of Russian oil sanctions led to a rebound in India's imports of Russian crude while China continues to import at high levels. Unsanctioning Iranian crude on water could, in theory, temporarily fill the medium-sour gap if Asian refiners, particularly Indian refiners and Chinese oil majors, can resolve payment and compliance issues," it added.

END TO DISCOUNTS

Discounts on these sanctioned barrels are narrowing or already flipping to premiums as demand rises and the buyer pool broadens, Vortexa said.

How Mumbai's new *benne dosa* love is rewiring QSR market

Davangere-style outlets are on a pan-India march with a scalable model

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Move over Udipi restaurants, those ubiquitous joints run by the Shettys that popularised South Indian fare across India. Now, it's the *benne dosa* joints that are taking over the quick service restaurant (QSR) market across Delhi, Gurugram, Ahmedabad, Mumbai and Bengaluru.

DARSHINI FORMAT

Mumbai has emerged as the launchpad for Bengaluru's 'Darshini' format to scale nationally on speed, efficiency and cost advantage. Sustained queues outside Rameshwaram Cafe at Churchgate for *benne dosa*, *podu idli*, and ghee-heavy *thattai idli*, months after the launch of the restaurant signal something more than novelty. They signal format viability, triggering a wave of replication.



HUGELY POPULAR. Rameshwaram Cafe's Churchgate outlet serves 20,000 *dosas* and *idlis* daily EMMANUEL JACKIE KARBHARI

From Bandra to Borivali and Navi Mumbai, and even Thane, over a dozen Bengaluru-style *benne dosa* outlets have opened in the last few months, showcasing a rapid shift from niche demand to a scalable, neighbourhood-level format.

There is 'Benne' in Bandra, Juhu and Chowpatty, 'The Benne House' in Ghatkopar, 'KTR' in Versova and 'Namma Benne House' in Borivali, each offering variations of the ghee-heavy Davangere-style *dosa*. In Thane,

at least five *benne dosa* outlets have opened back-to-back — 'Benne Rush', 'The House of Benne', 'Aura Benne Dosa', 'Benne Reserve' and 'Podi Kaappi'. In Navi Mumbai, newer entrants such as 'Benne Mane', 'Benne', 'Podi' and 'More', 'Benne Bliss Cafe' and 'Dakshinadi Village' are also gaining traction.

The numbers tell the story. Rameshwaram Cafe's 6,500 sq ft Churchgate outlet serves close to 20,000 *dosas* and *idlis* daily. Bengaluru-ori-

gin founders Akhil Iyer and Shriya Narayan have grown from a 12-seater Bandra outlet in 2024 to a multi-location brand, with a third Mumbai outlet and a Delhi presence in Greater Kailash II. They serve up 1,000-1,200 plates a day in Mumbai alone.

RESILIENT MODEL

At a time when the West Asia conflict is squeezing traditional gas-intensive, multi-cuisine kitchens, the Darshini-style formats, built around a tight menu, shorter cooking cycles and lean staffing, are proving resilient.

The unit economics are compelling. A kiosk costs ₹20-30 lakh to set up, a full franchise runs to ₹80 lakh to ₹1.2 crore.

With *dosas* priced in the ₹250-300 range, a stand-and-eat model allows for rapid table turns and strong throughput on a relatively modest initial outlay.

US not to levy tariffs on generic drugs, for now; patented medicines face 100% levy, with caveats

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

In possibly the first clear statement on generic drugs, the US administration has said that generic pharmaceutical products will not be subject to tariffs, for now.

This, even as a 100 per cent tariff has been imposed on patented drugs, where companies are not already in an alliance or in discussion to bring down prices for the US.

'SECURITY ISSUE'

Patented medicines remained a key part of the latest statement from US President Trump, citing a report from his Commerce Secretary, who investigated the impact of US imports of pharmaceuticals and pharmaceutical ingredients on national security, under Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act (1962).

The statement said,



"...The present quantities and circumstances of imports of pharmaceuticals and pharmaceutical ingredients threaten to impair the national security and economy."

Further, it added that, according to the Food and Drug Administration, "as of 2025, approximately 53 per cent of patented pharmaceutical products distributed domestically are produced outside the country. The degree of import reliance is significant at the API (active pharmaceutical ingredient) level, with only 15 per cent of pat-

ented APIs by volume domestically produced for the US market." The US President's statement indicated that the tariff would be zero for companies that have most favoured nation (MFN) pricing up to January 20, 2029. (MFN pricing pegs US prices on a par with the lowest international price on the same product.)

On generic drugs, the statement indicated Trump's decision "not to adjust imports of generic pharmaceuticals and their associated ingredients, including biosimilar products, at this time. This determination includes purchases of generic pharmaceuticals and ingredients for the Strategic API Reserve. I find that such products should not be subject to Section 232 tariffs at this time."

The generics status could change in a year, he said, if the administration finds circumstances that indicate a

need to take action on generic pharmaceuticals and associated ingredients as well.

BIG GENERICS MARKET

The US is a key market for several large Indian drug-makers, including Sun Pharma, Dr Reddy's Laboratories, Lupin, Glenmark and Zydus Lifesciences. Generic drugs are critical in improving access to affordable medicine in the US, industry representatives point out. India exports about \$10 billion worth of medicines to the US annually.

On the impact on Indian companies, only Sun Pharma looks to be affected as its innovative drug sales are over 50 per cent of its US sales (about 30 per cent of its revenues), Vishal Manchanda, Senior Vice-President (Institutional Research) with Systematix Group, told *businessline*. That is small in the US innovative drugs market, estimated at \$350 billion.

Apollo gets NCLT nod for corporate restructuring

Chennai: Apollo Hospitals Enterprise has received NCLT nod for its proposed corporate restructuring. The company informed the exchanges on Friday that the NCLT had approved its application for its proposed composite scheme of arrangement involving the restructuring of Apollo's healthcare and allied businesses across four entities — Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Ltd, Apollo Healthcare Ltd, Keimed Pvt Ltd and Apollo Healthcare Ltd. **OUR BUREAU**

Indian Oil Corporation says LPG supply stable

New Delhi: The Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) said LPG supply in India remains stable and adequate despite geopolitical disruptions to global energy markets, adding that domestic availability continues to be its top priority. IOC said it is delivering around 28 lakh cylinders daily, in line with normal levels prior to the current tensions. PTI

Asian News International
New Delhi

Mehli Mistry, a former trustee of three key trusts of the Tata Group including the Bai Hiralal Trust Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution (BHTNCI), on Friday formally objected to the appointment and continued representation of two trustees — Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — in the BHTNCI on the grounds that the said individuals are ineligible to qualify for the positions and their appointment as trustees in the said Trust is in blatant violation of a 1923 Trust Deed.

Mistry, in an objection-application filed to the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner, contended that the two trustees never met the

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The fallout of the West Asian war is set to hit India's cement sector with a lag, as a sharp rise in fuel and packaging costs, with limited room to increase prices, begins to squeeze margins from the June quarter.

While firms managed to cushion the impact in the March quarter — helped by steady demand, partial price pass-throughs and the use of lower-cost raw material inventory — the cost pressures are now intensifying.

A spike in fuel prices, coupled with a shortage of polypropylene-based cement bags as refineries di-

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

FMCG major Emami Ltd, which is planning to complete the acquisition of Axiom Ayurveda within three months, is looking to grow the topline of the beverage company to around ₹500 crore in the next three years.

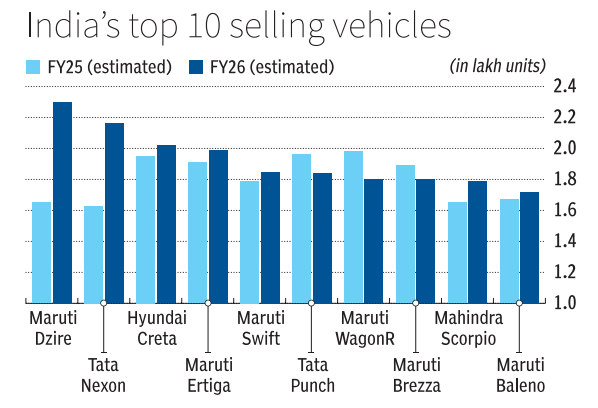
The Emami Group flagship has executed a definitive agreement to acquire the remaining around 73.5 per cent stake in Axiom, marking its formal entry into the beverage sector. The Har-

businessline.

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WAR IMPACT. Car major's six vehicles in top 10 of overall PV sales; company to take a call soon on price hikes

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi



lakh, mainly due to lack in demand of compact cars in the country, data from industry sources said.

In FY25, WagonR sales were recorded at more than 1.98 lakh units. However, in the top 10 list of India's highest selling PVs, MSIL still rules the market with six vehicles – Dzire (No 1), Er-tiga (No 4) with sales of around 1.99 lakh units, Swift (No 5) with around 1.85 lakh units, WagonR (No 7), Brezza (No 8) with around 1.8 lakh units and Baleno (No 10) with more than 1.72 lakh units.

The Dzire is the only sedan that MSIL sells out of its portfolio of around 20

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The Dzire is the only sedan that MSIL sells out of its portfolio of around 20

vehicles across segments, after the company stopped production of Ciaz last year. Powered by a 1.2-litre petrol engine, the Dzire is priced between ₹6.25 lakh and ₹9.31 lakh (ex-showroom), with six airbags as standard. It is also available in Maruti's S-CNG technology and also available in Tour S category for tax segment.

"We have not exited the sedan segment. We have introduced the full model change of Dzire in FY25. Dzire has been the No.1 model in the country in CY25 and FY26 with a volume of 2,29,130 units. It is very big achievement as in a market where the SUVs are ruling the most, a sedan emerges as the number one selling model. This shows there are customers who are looking for the sedan segment also," Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer,

Marketing & Sales, MSIL, told reporters in a recent call on sales performance.

He said there are still customers for all the form factors and all type of vehicles.

GST REDUCTION

Talking about demand in the small cars segment, Banerjee said post GST reduction, there was a huge demand for small cars, but there is pressure now because of commodity prices going up due to the West Asia war.

He added that since small car buyers are very price sensitive, MSIL has been absorbing the prices since January, but now as the commodity prices are still on the rise, it will take a call on price hikes soon for its products.

"Unfortunately, the commodity prices are going very high, so we need to pass them on to customers," he said.

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S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi



Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL) on Friday said it has added 502 service touchpoints in FY26, marking the highest-ever network expansion in a single fiscal by the company.

With this, MSIL's total after-sales service network has reached to 5,926 touchpoints, covering 3,000 cities and towns in India, the company said, adding that it aims to reach up 8,000 touchpoints by FY31.

MIXED BAG

The newly added service touchpoints comprise a mix of formats including Arene and Nexa workshops, Maruti Suzuki Sales and Service Points, Service-on-Wheels and Bodyshop-on-Wheels, it said.

“For a car customer, nothing gives more comfort than knowing that they can easily find a service touchpoint and spare parts whenever and wherever they need them. As

our customers are spread across the nation and their requirements continue to evolve, we are continuously innovating and expanding our service touchpoints,” Hisashi Takeuchi, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, MSIL, said.

MSIL inaugurated its first service workshop in 1983 and reached 1,000 service touchpoints by 1997. In May 2024, the firm announced the opening of its 5,000th service touchpoint.

Over the last five financial years, MSIL, along with its network partners, has significantly accelerated network expansion efforts, adding almost 2,000 service touchpoints.

qualifications to be appointed as trustees and stand expressly disqualified under the Trust Deed. He argued that, under Clauses 6 and 18 of the Deed, any such disqualified trustee must be treated as "deemed dead".

He specifically claimed that Srinivasan and Singh were never of the Parsi Zoroastrian faith and did not have permanent residence in Mumbai. Thus, they are deemed to attract automatic disqualification.

On this basis, Mistry sought a *suo motu* inquiry by the State's Charity Commissioner and requested the authority to direct all trustees to file affidavits confirming their eligibility.

"The Applicant/Objector is pained to bring to the notice of this Hon'ble Authority, that Applicants Nos 3 and

four amongst others, *ex facie*, never met the qualifications to become trustees and are expressly disqualified from acting as trustees. Any trustee who does not meet the qualifications are to be 'deemed to be dead' under Clauses 6 and 18 of the Trust Deed. Applicants Nos 3 and 4 have never been and cannot be of Parsi Zoroastrian faith. Further, Applicants Nos 3 and 4 do not have any permanent residence in Mumbai. Notably, the Trust Deed carves out a situation wherein if a person ceases to be of Zoroastrian faith, they cease to operate as if they are dead, thereby warranting a continuing investigation as to whether any trustee falls within the said category of being a Zoroastrian earlier, and having ceased to follow the Zoroastrian faith. The



Applicant/Objector prays for this Hon'ble Authority to initiate a detailed inquiry to be conducted on the said matter, by calling for an affidavit by each Applicant," the objection-application read.

Mistry further said that he, on the other hand, fulfils all eligibility requirements, as he is a Parsi Zoroastrian and maintains permanent residence in Mumbai. He called for similar sworn de-



clarations from all trustees to ensure compliance with the provisions of the Trust Agreements under the Trust Agreements, including their continued faith and residence. He argued that individuals who do not meet these mandatory qualifications cannot lawfully act as trustees. According to him, their appointments amount to cheating, fraud and criminal breach of trust, which constitute mal-

administration under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2024, and the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act, 1950.

APPOINTMENTS VOID

He asserted that their appointments are void from inception and that any actions taken by them as trustees are non-est in law and without authority. Mistry also clarified that his aim is only to expose the alleged illegal functioning of the Trust, including mismanagement and maladministration and is not intended to seek his reinstatement to the Trust. He reiterated his earlier stand and stated that his sole objective is to uphold the principles of the Trust's founding Will, honour the legacy of Ratan Tata, and safeguard its values for the welfare of the Parsi community.

As per the Tata Trusts website, the BHJTNCI is a philanthropic trust established in 1923, aiding Parsi and community welfare in Navsari, Gujarat. It is part of the allied Tata Trusts, which share a common Board of Trustees with the Sir Ratan Tata Trust.

Earlier in February 2026, Mistry, being a trustee on the board of the Tata Education and Development Trust, had also raised a concern on a separate issue pertaining to the proposed scrapping of the Vice-Chairman position across Tata Trusts. He argued that the Trust Deed contains no provision for such a role.

On November 4, 2025, Mistry, a long-time trustee of the Tata Trust, made a peaceful and honourable exit from the Trust, citing commit-

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Dabur India on Friday said it expects consolidated revenues in Q4 FY26 to grow in mid-single digits, with operating profit growing ahead of the topline. It added that strong domestic demand enabled it to offset challenges in international markets, particularly West Asia.

The FMCG major added that it “remains” watchful of the evolving geopolitical landscape and will continue to take proactive measures to mitigate any potential impact on its operations.

It added that India's FMCG business witnessed sequential recovery in demand and is likely to record high single-digit growth.

In terms of International business, the company said, "While West Asia business was impacted on account of the US-Israel- Iran conflict, its other key markets like Turkey, Bangladesh and UK performed well and continued to grow in double-digits in constant currency terms. We expect our international business to record low-single digit growth in rupee terms."

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai



The ₹8,850 crore that Sammaan Capital Ltd (SCL) will receive in tranches from Abu Dhabi-based investment firm International Holding Company PJSC (IHC) over the next 18 months will ensure growth capital for the mortgage-focused non-banking finance company (NBFC) for the next five years, helping it diversify into personal loans, loans against gold, and small business loans.

Powered by the capital infusion, the NBFC's consolidated AUM (assets under management) is expected to grow to about ₹1.3-1.5 lakh crore by 2029 from the December-end 2025 level of ₹64,200 crore, said Gagan Banga, MD & CEO, SCL.

"Between 2018-19 till about 2023, the company was fighting some sort of an

existential crisis. Then, in 2024, we raised around ₹5,000 crore of capital, which allowed us to stabilise our AUM, borrowings, ratings, etc. Having done that, over the course of the last couple of years we started growing again," he told *businessline*.

Banga emphasised that there are two macro trends in the economy — first is that there is consolidation happening in the financial services space, where the big is getting bigger, and the

second is that over the course of at least the next 20 years, India has a fairly well defined predictable growth path ahead of it.

“Given these two backgrounds, we needed to have a very strong foundation of a strong parent, which would enable us to focus on growth versus navigating the environment. The parent navigates the environment for you... And so we can focus on growth now,” Banga said.

CAPITAL INJECTION

Recently, the NBFC announced that IHC through its affiliate, Avenir Investment RSC LTD, will become the promoter of SCL, acquiring 41.5 per cent stake via a preferential allotment of equity shares and warrants in the company.

The NBFC has received an initial tranche of ₹5,652 crore (\$600 million) towards the allotment of equity shares and warrants, with an

QUICKLY.

Forex reserves decline by \$10.29 b to \$688 b



Mumbai: The country's forex reserves dropped by \$10.288 billion to \$688.058 billion during the week ended March 27, the Reserve Bank of India said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the overall reserves had declined by \$11.413 billion to \$698.346 billion. The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year, before the onset of the West Asia conflict. **PTI**

NCL supplies 137 mt dry fuel in FY26

New Delhi: Coal India arm NCL on Friday said that it supplied a record 137.08 million tonnes (mt) of coal to its customers in power and other sectors during 2025-26, significantly reinforcing India's energy security amid surging domestic demand. Of the total dispatch, 86 per cent, equivalent to 117.85 mt, was supplied to coal-based power plants. **PTI**

Trump vows to hit more Iranian infrastructure

HOSTILITIES INTENSIFY. Tehran attacks Kuwait desalination plant; UN Security Council to vote today on reopening of the Strait of Hormuz

Reuters/PTI
Washington/Cairo/United Nations

US President Donald Trump threatened to extend attacks on civilian infrastructure in Iran after a US strike cut a major highway bridge on Thursday, prompting a defiant response from Iran, which hit a water plant in Kuwait and said more would follow.

Attacks on transport, power and water facilities vital for the populations of Iran and the neighbouring Gulf countries risk deepening the war, which has already killed thousands and threatens to cause lasting damage to the world economy.

On Thursday, Trump posted footage on social media showing dust and smoke billowing up as US strikes hit the newly constructed B1 bridge between Tehran and nearby Karaj, which was due to open to traffic this year.

“Our Military, the greatest and most powerful (by far) anywhere in the World, hasn’t even started destroying what’s left in Iran. Bridges next, then Electric Power Plants!,” he



BROKEN LINK. The B1 bridge that was damaged by a US strike in Karaj, Iran **REUTERS**

wrote in a subsequent post.

In response, Iran’s Revolutionary Guard Corps said it would hit “all assets of the Israeli regime and the US in fuel, energy, economic centres and power plants across the region”.

The Iranian military also said it had shot down a US F-35 fighter jet over central Iran. There was no immediate comment from the US military.

KUWAIT WATER PLANT
As the two sides exchanged taunts, an Iranian attack on

Friday hit a water desalination and power plant in Kuwait, a major US ally in the region, causing material damage to parts of the facility, Kuwait’s electricity and water ministry said.

Nearly five weeks after the war started with a joint US-Israeli aerial assault, Trump is under pressure to find a quick resolution. Negotiations conducted via intermediaries with new leaders in Iran have shown little sign of progress, and pessimism at home has been growing, with polls showing most

Americans opposed to the war. At the same time, the economic impact has been ratcheting up sharply around the world, with Iran’s grip on the strategic shipping lane in the Strait of Hormuz giving it a choke hold on oil and gas supplies vital to the global economy.

As he threatened more attacks, Trump said Iran’s leadership “knows what has to be done, and has to be done, FAST!” But there has been little sign of acquiescence from Tehran.

“Striking civilian struc-

tures, including unfinished bridges, will not compel Iranians to surrender,” Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said.

UNSC MEET

Meanwhile, the UN Security Council will vote on a draft resolution proposed by Bahrain on Saturday on reopening the Strait of Hormuz, even as permanent members China and Russia voiced opposition to earlier versions of the text that would have allowed use of force by countries.

The draft Security Council resolution affirms that the Strait of Hormuz is open for all transit passage. No state has the right to close or control it.

It authorises States to take “exclusively defensive measures” to secure transit passage and deter any acts to impede international navigation through the Strait.

It also provides a clear legal basis for all States to mobilise and support safe passage while following international law and international humanitarian law. The draft resolution says that countries using this authorisation must notify and re-

port to the UN, ensuring transparency and adherence to international law. It creates a monitoring mechanism with monthly reporting by the UN Secretary-General so the UN Security Council can take further action based on new developments, the Permanent Mission of the UAE to the UN said.

Bahrain, supported by the GCC and Jordan, has proposed the Security Council resolution on the Strait of Hormuz, which will be put up for a vote in the 15-nation Security Council on Saturday.

Bahrain is currently the President of the Council for the month of April.

World food prices rise set to continue if Iran war lasts: FAO

Reuters
Paris

World food prices climbed in March to their highest level since September last year and could rise further if the West Asia conflict that pushed up energy prices continues, the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization said on Friday.

“Price rises since the conflict began have been modest, driven mainly by higher oil prices and cushioned by ample global cereal supplies,” FAO Chief Economist Maximo Torero said in a statement.

But if the conflict lasts over

40 days and input costs remain high, farmers may reduce inputs, plant less, or switch crops to less intensive fertilizer crops, he said.

“Those choices will hit future yields and shape our food supply and commodity prices for the rest of this year and all of the next,” he added.

The FAO Food Price Index, which measures changes in a basket of globally traded food commodities, rose by 2.4 per cent from its revised February level.

It is 1 per cent above its value a year ago, although nearly 20 per cent below its March 2022 peak, reached after the start of the war in Ukraine.

Adani Ports eyes 1 bt of cargo by 2030

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Billionaire Gautam Adani on Friday set an ambitious target for Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) of handling one billion tonnes of cargo annually by 2030, while also signalling a shift in organisational structure to support scale and speed.

Speaking at an event to mark the APSEZ crossing 500 million tonnes of cargo, Adani said the next phase of growth would be driven by compounding momentum, with logistics and marine services expected to expand five-fold over the next five years.

He pointed out that cargo volumes, which took 16 years to reach the first 100 million tonnes, have since accelerated sharply, with the most recent additions achieved in just two years each.

With logistics as a strategic lever for India’s economic rise, Adani said the group’s future ambitions are “not just bold but essential,” positioning Adani Ports at the centre of the country’s infrastructure and trade expansion.

3-LAYER STRUCTURE

The group is moving towards a three-layer structure aimed at flattening hierarchies and pushing decision-making closer to operations. “This is not about cost reduction. It is about empowerment,” Adani said, emphasising that future-ready organisations will prioritise speed and responsiveness over centralised control.

He stressed that large infrastructure networks cannot be run from a distant command centre, adding



Adani Group Chairman
Gautam Adani

that execution strength lay at the “last mile” — at ports, yards and logistics nodes where real-time decisions are made. The new structure is intended to enhance ownership and accountability among frontline teams, enabling faster responses and reducing bureaucratic friction.

Adani added that the shift would be accompanied by a broader cultural change, where initiative is encouraged and accountability is “embraced with pride.” The focus, he said, would be on building “low-friction organisations” driven by capability and judgment rather than compliance-heavy systems.

Beyond internal restructuring, he also underscored the importance of strengthening partner ecosystems. As the organisation flattens, APSEZ will aim to deepen relationships with vendors and partners, ensuring their financial health and long-term resilience. Stronger partners, he said, translate into better execution and system-wide stability.

“Velocity will come from empowerment, stability from dignity, and long-term strength from mutual prosperity,” he said.

Average time for issuing I-T refunds hits a 3-year high in FY26

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Investigation into bogus donations and fraudulent tax deductions caused unusual delays in tax refunds for FY26, according to a report submitted by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) to a Parliamentary panel. In response, the panel recommended the aggressive implementation of advanced AI-driven risk-scoring algorithms to streamline the process and prioritise honest taxpayers.

REFUND TIMELINES

As of January 31, the average time for issuing tax refunds climbed to 35 days for FY26, marking a three-year high.

While this average remains within the official taxpayer charter limits, the volume of significant delays has surged.

Nearly 27 lakh income-tax refund applications were



processed with delays beyond the normative 90-day period, the highest in a three-year period. Refund processing by the tax department starts only after the return is e-verified by the taxpayer. Usually, it takes 4-5 weeks for the refund to be credited to the taxpayer’s account.

However, FY26 saw more delay than normal. When quizzed by the Parliamentary panel, the CBDT Chairman said: “This year, it so happened that in July 2025, similar to the case that we re-

ferred to — that is, the Biryani case — verifications were carried out by the tax department in respect of bogus deductions claimed, donations, 80G, and so on.” This exercise was undertaken in July 2025.

VERIFICATION

“What we got from that exercise was a sense that a substantial number of cases involved fraudulent or incorrect deductions being claimed. Based on that input, we undertook a similar exercise once the returns were

Direct tax refunds

FY	Average time taken			Issuance after 90 days
	Count (in cr)	Quantum (in ₹ lakh cr)	Avg No. of days	Count (in lakh)
2023-24	3.41	2.4	25	12.73
2024-25	3.64	3.42	24	14.18
2025-26 (Up to Jan 31)	3.38	1.62	35	26.96

Source: CBDT response to Standing Committee

Govt mulls steps to scale up production of induction heaters, cooktops

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government is learnt to be looking at measures to encourage companies to ramp up production of induction heaters, induction cooktops and compatible utensils. This comes at a time when these categories are witnessing high demand due to concerns over LPG availability amidst the West Asia conflict.

In this regard, a meeting was reportedly held on Friday by the Commerce Ministry with the participation of senior officials from various key Ministries, such as

Power, the DPIIT and the DGFT to discuss steps that could be taken to enable companies to increase the production of induction heaters and cooktops, among others. The meeting was reportedly chaired by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal.

GEOPOLITICAL TENSIONS

The ongoing geopolitical tensions have let to disruption of movement of ships through Strait of Hormuz, which has led to concerns over imports of crude oil and natural gas.

Products such as induction heaters and cooktops and electric kettles and cook-



WAR IMPACT. The move comes at a time when these products are witnessing high demand due to concerns over LPG availability amidst the West Asia conflict. **PTI**

ers have seen a surge in demand as consumers are increasingly looking at

leased. Wherever the quantum was high, we held them back and nudged the taxpayer towards compliance,” the Chairman said.

Once the returns were filed, the analysis was carried out and correlated with the ongoing investigations.

“The numbers that emerged were large. Therefore, the issue before us was how to proceed and effect the necessary corrections. Based on the analysis, we identified high-risk refunds. Wherever we found that the quantum of refund was small, those refunds were re-

AI-DRIVEN SOLUTIONS
Meanwhile, the panel suggested that deploying advanced AI-driven risk-scoring algorithms could significantly help separate genuine, low-risk filings from suspicious ones instantly.

“This will ensure that while deeper scrutiny is strictly applied to high-risk cases to check false claims and protect the exchequer, the vast majority of honest taxpayers receive their refunds within the timeline,” it said in a report, which was tabled in Parliament during the just-concluded Budget session.

Chief Executive Officer, Wonderchef, told *businessline*, “We have been witnessing 8-10 times higher demand for induction cooktops in the past three weeks due to LPG issues triggered by the West Asia conflict. In fact, we have also seen 3-5 times higher demand for other categories such as kettles, rice cookers, Nutri-pot (electric pressure cookers) and OTG.

“Given the dynamic geopolitical conditions, we believe we will continue to see high demand for these categories for the next 12-24 months, especially given the relatively low-price barriers of induction cooktops. Ac-

cordingly, we are ramping up production of these categories to cater to the higher demand.”

Industry executive some of the components required for manufacturing such products are imported, while some of the components are sourced domestically.

To maintain the supply chain in other sectors, the government on Thursday exempted the import of critical petrochemical products from customs duty for three months till June 30, giving relief to sectors like pharmaceuticals, chemicals and textiles, and ensuring supply stability amid the ongoing West Asia crisis.

RBI rolls out benchmark strategy for market borrowings for 9 States on pilot basis

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India has decided to introduce Benchmark Issuance Strategy (BIS) for market borrowings, on a pilot basis, for nine States based on their concurrence, starting FY27.

The nine States included in the pilot are Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Telangana and Uttar Pradesh. The BIS would involve issuing securities in specific benchmark tenor buckets as per the pre-announced calendar.

“As their cash and debt manager, Reserve Bank has been sensitising States about



NEW STRATEGY

The BIS will involve issuing securities in specific benchmark tenor buckets as per the pre-announced calendar

adoption of BIS for their market borrowings. Adoption of this strategy is aimed at enhancing transparency

and providing greater clarity to investors...Going forward, other States/UTs are expected to adopt the BIS,” RBI said in a statement.

The quantum of total market borrowings by the State Governments/UTs for the quarter April-June 2026, is expected to be ₹2,54,509 crore. The borrowing by States in the first quarter of FY27 is lower than the quantum of borrowing indicated in last year’s first quarter calendar of ₹2,73,255 crore.

In the first quarter of FY27, the nine States that have adopted the BIS will collectively borrow ₹1,53,900 crore. The remaining States will collectively borrow ₹1,00,609 crore.

AIEBA writes to FM for probe into issues raised by former HDFC Bank chief

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The All India Bank Employees’ Association (AIEBA) has written to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman seeking a comprehensive inquiry into the issues raised by Atanu Chakraborty, former Part-Time Chairman of HDFC Bank, in his resignation letter.

In his resignation letter dated March 17, Chakraborty said that certain “happenings and practices” within the bank were not in congruence with his personal values and ethics. The association has sought the government’s



intervention for assessing the governance, compliance, and risk management practices at India’s second largest private sector bank.

Further, there should be public disclosure of inquiry findings to ensure transparency and maintain depositor confidence.

CH Venkatachalam, General Secretary, AIEBA, said the government should initi-

ate an independent probe, if warranted, and get the matter examined by appropriate Parliamentary Committees, considering the systemic implications and public interest involved. “The Indian banking system — whether public or private — operates fundamentally on public trust and public funds. Therefore, it is essential that all banks, irrespective of ownership, remain answerable to the public and subject to the highest standards of transparency and accountability.

“We urge you to intervene in the matter to safeguard the interest of the 12 crore customers of the bank in particular and people at large in

general so that millions of customers, depositors and stakeholders feel reassured,” he said.

He said the explicit mention of ethical incongruence by an Independent Director is highly unusual and warrants immediate investigation. “We observe that RBI has come out with their statement that the deposits in the bank are safe. It is quite understandable.”

In his resignation letter, Chakraborty cited “certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over last two years, are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics.”

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QUICKLY.

Ducati Superleggera V4 Centenario unveiled



The latest iteration of the Panigale blurs the lines between a competition bike and a road-legal superbike like we've never seen before. A carbon fibre frame, swingarm, wheels and even the front fork's outer tubes. It's also the first road bike to sport carbon-ceramic disc brakes. With a 1103 cc V4 powerhouse putting 225 bhp (246 bhp in race config) and a kerb weight of just 167 kg, this is one of the most extreme road-legal bikes till date. And just 500 units are to be made, which seals its exclusivity.

2026 Mercedes-Benz GLS out now



The German brand has given a fresh design, new tech and revised powertrains to its flagship three-row SUV. It features redesigned headlights, grille and new wheel designs. Inside, the cabin has integrated the MBUX Superscreen with three 12.3-inch displays and improved comfort features. Engine options include a 3.0-litre inline-six producing around 370 bhp and an updated V8 with up to 522 bhp, paired with a 9-speed automatic and standard all-wheel drive. There's also a new cloud-based suspension system and enhanced driver-assistance tech. The SUV is expected to reach global markets first, with an India launch likely by late 2026.

RE Guerrilla 450 Apex launched at ₹2.49 lakh



Royal Enfield's neo-retro roadster gets an update in the form of a new variant. In the Apex trim, the Guerrilla 450 features a lowered aluminium handlebar, road-focused Vredestein Centauro ST+ tyres and two new ride modes — Street and Sport. Further, there are a couple of visual changes like a rear-seat cowl and a small fairing over the headlight. There are no changes to the 452 cc liquid-cooled single-cylinder engine or the suspension and brakes. The standard model also features updated ride modes and improved CEAT tyres.

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RENAULT INDIA

The OG Returns

MAKING A COMEBACK. The Duster created a segment from scratch, and then watched its rivals overtake it. Understandably, it wants another go

Anubhav Sharma

When the Renault Duster arrived in July 2012, it did something straightforward but consequential. It put a properly capable monocoque SUV in a price bracket that hadn't seen one before. Buyers responded immediately — nearly 40,000 units were sold in its first year and 1,00,000 units by 2014. More importantly, it showed the rest of the industry that the appetite for an accessible C-segment SUV in India was very real. Hyundai, for one, was paying close attention; its Creta arrived in 2015 and has dominated the segment ever since.

The Duster, meanwhile, didn't keep pace; updates came slowly and the competition pulled ahead. By February 2022, Renault ended production after nearly 2,00,000 units sold over a decade. The segment the Duster had helped build had simply moved on without it.

Four years later, it's back in a segment that is now super crowded with the likes of the Hyundai Creta, Kia Seltos, Skoda Kushaq, Volkswagen Taigun, Maruti Suzuki Grand Vitara and Toyota Urban Cruiser Hyryder — all competing for the same buyer. Two days across Delhi-NCR — expressways, city traffic and the kind of urban roads no manufacturer ever puts in a press release — gave us a fair read on whether this return has potential.

RUGGED OUTSIDE

The new Duster makes its intentions clear before you even open the door. Bold 'DUSTER' lettering sits across the grille where a badge would normally go. Y-shaped LED DRLs frame a front that is wide and upright. A muscular bumper and silver skid plate complete the picture. It looks rugged and purposeful without overdoing it, and it still looks like the Duster, which is a good thing.

The proportions are taller and more planted than the outgoing model. Body cladding runs along the length of the car, 18-inch alloys



COMFORT ZONE. Rear-seat comfort is good, with decent legroom and headroom. Overall cabin experience is promising, with tech and features galore! RENAULT INDIA

fill the arches well (lower variants get 17-inch alloy/steel wheels) and roof rails rated to 50 kg add a note of utility. At the rear, connected LED tail-lamps span the tailgate in a light bar, an India-specific detail absent on the global Dacia version. It's a small touch, but it signals that Renault has paid attention to this market rather than simply shipping a global product over.

Ten colour options include dual-tone combinations. It is a design that wears its intent honestly and looks like it can handle itself away from the tarmac, which is what the Duster has always been about.

MODERN INSIDE

Step inside and the generational gap from the old car is obvious. The dashboard is layered and well-assembled, with soft-touch leatherette across the upper half. The front seats are well-bolstered, ventilated on top variants, and offer six-way power adjustment. The driving position is easy to find and the raised centre console feels contemporary.

Rear-seat comfort feels adequate for adults on most journeys. Legroom is reasonable rather than

generous, and three-abreast seating is manageable without being the most comfortable arrangement for longer runs. Headroom is good, helped by the high roofline. Boot space is 518 litres to the parcel shelf and 700 litres to the roof, and it comes with a powered tailgate on top variants.

Harder plastics show up on the lower door cards and the bottom half of the dashboard. They're not immediately obvious, but at top-variant prices, they're difficult to ignore.

PATIENCE, THEN PLENTY

The 1.3-litre turbo-petrol sits at the heart of the lineup, producing 160.7 bhp and 28.5 kg-m — the most powerful engine currently offered in this segment. It comes with either a 6-speed manual or a 6-speed DCT automatic, although the latter is the more natural fit. Shifts are clean and well-timed, but in the stop-start rhythm of Delhi traffic, it takes a bit of time to get used to. It tends to upshift too soon, perhaps for efficiency, and that leads to a bit of a flat spot when you finally clear traffic.

In a market tilting increasingly

toward strong hybrids and EVs, where torque arrives before you've finished thinking about it, the 1.3's character takes a moment to appreciate. Below 2000 rpm, it asks for patience; turbo lag is present and, by current standards, noticeable. Reach for the paddle shifter, drop a gear, let the engine find its stride, and the response comes with conviction. It pulls cleanly through the range from there. On open expressway stretches, once it's in its element, it feels properly capable.

A 1.0-litre turbo-petrol producing 97.6 bhp is also available for those who prioritise efficiency. A 1.8-litre strong hybrid is expected to arrive around Diwali 2026, but don't hold your breath. Renault India said that hybrid bookings for the year are already full.

The Duster's ground clearance of 212 mm is among the highest in this class and earns its daily keep in Delhi-NCR. The suspension feels calibrated for Indian road conditions; it absorbs broken surfaces without drama and, on the expressway, the car settles into a composed, planted stride. Steering weight suits both settings: Not too light at speed, not too heavy in the city.

WIRED IN

For returning Duster fans, the tech upgrades will be the biggest change they'll notice. The OpenR multimedia system runs Google built-in natively. For instance, Maps, Assistant and Play Store work directly through the car without mirroring a phone. A 10.1-inch infotainment screen sits alongside a 10.25-inch digital driver's display, both angled toward the driver. Wireless Apple CarPlay and Android Auto are present, too. And I have to say, the digital driver's display and its various faces are refreshingly good — clean UI and all the information a driver would need.

Dual-zone climate control, panoramic sunroof, 48-colour ambient lighting, a wireless Qi2 charger with a cooling vent above it, a 360-degree camera and ventilated front seats feature on top variants. An AQI display with a PM 2.5 filter is a feature that makes particular sense in our metros now. Level 2 ADAS, a first for Renault in India, covers 17 driver assistance functions and is available on upper trims. A warranty of up to 7 years or 1,50,000 km is offered across the range.

FULL CIRCLE

Priced from ₹10.49 lakh to ₹18.49 lakh (ex-showroom, Delhi), the Duster covers this segment from end to end. The 1.3-litre DCT is the variant most buyers will want. Its ride quality in Delhi conditions, the feature set in upper trims and the honest, purposeful character of the car are what make its case. The turbo lag and the hard plastics in the lower cabin are the concessions for the buyer to make. Neither really undermines the Duster experience, but both are worth factoring into a variant decision.

What the Duster has managed is something harder to achieve than a strong spec sheet. It has come back with a clear identity. In a class where most cars are chasing the same formula, it still feels like itself. The segment it created may be bigger and more demanding than when it left, but the original has a say in the matter again.

@TheMotorGram

Ruman Devmane

The average EV scooter of today can do everything short of launching a space shuttle. Somehow, the honest-to-goodness narrative once attached to the scooter, once seen as the last word in two-wheel convenience and nothing more, has almost been forgotten. The Yamaha EC-06 is refreshingly different.

Yamaha, you may remember, invested in EV start-up, River, back in 2024 and the EC-06, the brand's first-ever EV for India, is based on the Indie. Fortunately, this isn't a mere badge-engineering exercise. At ₹1.68 lakh (ex-showroom), it sure isn't priced aggressively, but nothing on the scooter, visually at least, implies it needs to be.

It's a somewhat quirky-looking scooter, its boxy lines implying a sense of refined robustness. The split square headlight is an LED unit and its swept-back bodywork is all very high-quality, including the paint finish which has a subtle flake treatment to it — nice! It sits on a pair of 14-inch wheels with suitably chunky rubber and a disc brake at either end, and while there is a mildly forward-set stance to it (floorboard, seat), seating yourself on it takes away any misgivings.

HEALTHY EFFICIENCY

As a large rider, I found the rider's seat quite comfortable, although there wasn't much space left for a pillion at that point. Ergonomically, there's no learning curve for



LONG WAY ROUND. The Yamaha EC-06 is a refreshing electric scooter that trades sensationalism for longevity and wholesomeness

you to surmount; you can very simply twist the throttle and take off. It's super intuitive. There are ride modes (Eco, Standard and Power) and Eco is best left for hardcore efficiency as it strongly limits performance. Powered by a 4-kWh battery pack that pro-

duces 8.9 bhp and 2 kg-m, the EC-06 leans towards performance quite convincingly.

I spent the majority of my time in Standard and Power modes, either of which offer really happy acceleration that feels sufficient without being overly aggressive.

It's got ample grunt to cope with steep gradients and, in an urban environment, performance is healthy. On clean, empty stretches, I hit 85 kph on the speedometer, with room for more to come. Oddly, Yamaha's top-speed claim is 79 kph. What I



LASTING IMPRESSION. Unconventional styling is still easy on the eye. Finish levels are great; switchgear, instrumentation and comfort quotient all impress RUMAN DEVMANE

didn't like was having to roll off the throttle to switch between modes; it's mighty inconvenient especially when committing to an overtake.

Yamaha claims 169 km of range (IDC), although under aggressive testing (far from a real-world simulation) there was a severe drop in the state of charge. I'd say you can extract 100 km of range from it, riding mindfully. Perhaps the paramount achievement of this really well-engineered scooter is that it entirely takes your mind off 'trivialities' such as range. I was so immersed and happy riding the EC-06, I nearly forgot to look at the range indi-

cator! Not advisable behaviour, of course. Equally enjoyable is its dynamics package. The handling is spot-on, predictable and poised, and the suspension, while a bit firm up front, offers a good balance between comfort and agility. I wouldn't call it plush, though.

Practicality is a bit of a let-down, however. The underseat storage is 24.5 litres (the Indie has a 43-litre boot), although the Indie's 12-litre glovebox has been replaced with a charging port which is definitely convenient. Charging itself, however, isn't so. The EC-06 doesn't support fast charging at present, which trans-

lates to a 0-80 per cent charge time of 8 hours, while 100 per cent takes 10 hours! This limits the EC-06 to a very specific use case. If it works for you, I truly envy you.

With strong foundations, an emphasis on quality and a gimmick-free approach, I'd say Yamaha has a promising road ahead with the EC-06. It's a scooter you must definitely consider if you want a well-built, long-term scooter ownership experience. Or Yamaha can do one better and plonk a petrol engine in it!

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● FOCUS ON TAMIL NADU

BJP releases names of 27 candidates for Assembly polls; Annamalai not in list

NO THREAT. BJP downplays actor Vijay’s political entry, asserting that the main contest would be between the NDA and the DMK

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Friday announced its list of 27 candidates for the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls. State President Nainar Nagenthran will contest from Sattur and Union Minister and Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament L Murugan from Avinashi (SC).

Interestingly, the list did not include the name of former State President S Annamalai, amid speculation that he would contest either from Coimbatore (North) or Modakkurichi. In Chennai, former State President Tamilisai Soundararajan will contest from Mylapore and M Rajasimhan Mahindra (M Ashwinkumar) from Avadi.

Some of the other prominent contestants are Vanathi Srinivasan from Coimbatore (North), who defeated Kamal Haasan last time from Coimbatore South. However, this time, the AIADMK will contest from Coim-

batore (South). Raama Sreenivasan will contest from Madurai South, MR Gandhi from Nagercoil and GBS K Nagendran from Ramanathapuram.

S Vijayadharani will contest from Vilvancode constituency, which she previously won as a Congress candidate before switching sides. In Vilvancode, she will contest against a CPI (M) candidate.

Narayanan Thirupathy, chief spokesperson of the party’s State unit, rejected criticism of the delay in announcing candidates, and said the announcement follows a “well-defined internal process”. He also dismissed allegations that the timing of the candidate list was due to internal pressures over seat allocation.

NO RALLY PLANNED
Amid reports of PM Narendra Modi cancelling his road show in Chennai on Saturday due to a delay in candidate selection, Thirupathy said the Prime Minister is sched-



FULL OF FERVOUR. Annamalai campaigning in support of BJP candidate VP Ramalingam in Puducherry

uled to meet senior party leaders in Chennai before leaving for Kochi on Saturday afternoon. “There was no plan to hold a rally or roadshow in Chennai. It was mere speculation,” he said.

Speaking to *businessline*, Thirupathy said the candidate selection involves multiple layers of consultation before final approval by the party’s central leadership. “This is not a delay. It is a

process,” he said, adding that effective campaigning begins only after nomination scrutiny is completed.

He explained that inputs are gathered from district and constituency units, after which the State leadership shortlists three candidates per seat. The final candidate is then chosen by the BJP’s Central Election Committee.

“In every constituency, we

typically see 10-15 aspirants. The State selection team filters three names, and from those, one candidate is finalised at the national level,” he said.

SEAT-SHARING
On seat-sharing within the alliance, Thirupathy said the arrangement was reached by consensus. “All constituencies are equal in an alliance. Some seats we may prefer, some our partners may prefer, but decisions are mutually agreed on,” he said.

Stepping up criticism of the ruling DMK, Thirupathy accused the government of failing on law and order, governance and economic development.

He alleged a rise in crimes, particularly against women and children, and described it as a “larger social failure”. He also criticised the State’s performance in emerging sectors, such as semiconductors and artificial intelligence, arguing that Tamil Nadu lagged behind Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh and

Karnataka due to corruption and policy shortcomings.

According to him, the upcoming Assembly election would be a referendum on what the BJP calls the DMK’s “Dravidian model” of governance.

‘LIMITED IMPACT’
Dismissing the political entry of actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay, Founder of Tamil Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), Thirupathy said his electoral impact would be limited. “He is new to politics, and this is his first election. There is no clarity on ideology or vision. At best, he may attract his fan base, but politically we do not see a major impact,” he said.

Responding to large crowds at Vijay’s events, he said such turnouts for film personalities do not necessarily translate into votes. Thirupathy maintained that the main contest in the State would be between the BJP-led NDA and the DMK, even as Vijay has positioned his party as a key challenger.

‘Special session of Parliament aimed at leveraging women’s quota to influence voters’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Congress alleged that the Centre’s decision to convene a special session of Parliament from April 16 to 18 violates the Model Code of Conduct as it is aimed at leveraging the Women’s Reservation Bill to influence voters in West Bengal, Kerala, Assam, Puducherry and Tamil Nadu.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the timing of the session, coinciding with peak campaigning in both States, suggested an electoral motive rather than legislative urgency.

“The special session is actually an electoral session,” he said, alleging the government intended to derive political benefit in the two poll-bound States.

Ramesh said Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju had written to Congress President and Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge, proposing discussions on amendments related to the Women’s Reservation Bill.

In response, Kharge suggested that the government convene an all-party meeting after April 29, once the elect-



Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh

oral process in five States concludes, instead of holding separate consultations with individual parties.

According to Ramesh, the Opposition parties had unanimously conveyed this request on March 24, citing their engagement in election campaigns. Despite this, the government went ahead and announced the special session, which he termed an “arbitrary and unilateral” decision.

He noted that the Women’s Reservation Bill was passed in 2023, and said the Congress had demanded its implementation from the 2024 general elections.

While welcoming the proposal to implement the measure, Ramesh said there was no urgency that warranted convening a session during the election period.

In Thiruvananthapuram, CPI(M) mobilises ground force while BJP seeks breakthrough

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) has pushed its cadre deep into neighbourhoods across Thiruvananthapuram, determined to blunt what the Bharatiya Janata Party hopes will be its fresh appeal against the ruling Left.

The result has been a tightly coordinated show of strength, with Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan’s rallies swelling with supporters ferried in from booth-level networks, signalling a direct CPI (M) versus BJP contest in key pockets of the capital.

The CPI(M)’s familiar makeshift campaign offices lining arterial roads appeared unusually quiet through the day, giving an impression of thinning presence until the reason became clear. The cadres had not withdrawn, they had dispersed.

“Don’t be fooled into thinking the cadres have fled offices to seek the comfort of their homes,” said A Sasidharan Nair, a former area committee member of the CPI(M) and currently a branch member.

LEFT’S STRATEGY
“They were under strict orders to fan out, bulk up the



LEFT OR RIGHT? A deserted office of the LDF sporting a cutout of candidate VK Prasanth in Thiruvananthapuram

crowds, and pad the headcount at the Chief Minister’s meetings,” Nair explained.

Pinarayi Vijayan was scheduled to address back-to-back meetings across three constituencies that spill into the city from every direction. The constituencies, Vattiyoorkavu, Kazhakkootam and Nemom, are central to the CPI(M)’s defensive strategy in the district. They are not merely routine contests, but seats the party cannot afford to lose at a time when the BJP is seeking to expand its footprint beyond isolated pockets.

In Vattiyoorkavu, sitting MLA VK Prasanth squares off against K Muralaeddharan, Congress veteran, and R Sreelekha, the State’s first woman IPS officer and DGP, who carries the BJP’s hopes.

Nair, however, was unimpressed by the suspense. He predicted a cakewalk for Prasanth, with only the size of victory margin bothering him. Sreekumar, a Democratic Youth Federation of India functionary representing the party’s younger brigade, nodded along in agreement. He dismissed Muralaeddharan with a casual *varatthan* (outsider) remark, and treated Sreelekha’s credentials with a shrug. “Police officers,” he suggested with a grin, “don’t always get a well-directed traffic signal while transitioning into politics.”

Within the CPM’s internal ecosystem, confidence remains visible despite repeated references to anti-incumbency. Suresh Vellimangalam, News Editor of party mouthpiece *Deshabhimani* in Thiruvananthapuram,

sounded quietly assured that the LDF’s electoral arithmetic remained intact. “Critics keep shouting anti-incumbency,” he shrugged, “but step onto the ground and you’ll find voters quite happy to stick with their sitting MLAs. That’s precisely why we’ve fielded 56 of them again.” He reeled off examples: Linto Joseph from Thiruvambady, MS Arun Kumar from Mavelikkara and VK Prasanth in Vattiyoorkavu. All are “star performers”, complete with glowing reviews, loyal audiences and the rare distinction of voters who seem reluctant to let them go.

NEMOM BECKONS
Yet, if the CPI(M) is guarding its vote across the Capital, Nemom offers the BJP its clearest opening. Here, cadres of the National Democratic Alliance appeared to be building momentum behind Rajeev Chandrasekhar, the party’s State President, who is seeking to convert organisational energy into legislative presence.

Cutouts are spread across cross junctions, billboards multiply along approach roads, and nearly every available surface carries his image alongside Narendra Modi’s, underscoring the BJP’s attempt to nationalise what

has traditionally been a Left-dominated political landscape.

At the centre of Nemom’s campaign grid stands the BJP’s five-floor, air-conditioned campaign hub, a command centre designed to translate booth-level inputs into real-time strategy. The building functions as a data nerve centre, staffed largely by young volunteers monitoring feedback from the field and feeding it into digital outreach systems.

“Yes, we work here in shifts from 9 am to 6 pm,” said young Aravind and Anjana, peering over their desktops while furiously keying in data streaming in from the field via phone calls, video updates and the occasional breathless in-person reports. The operation resembles a war room, where booth-level feedback is quickly converted into messaging and mobilisation. The data gain significant traction on social media, said Anjana.

“We’re getting good feedback from the ground. The candidate is not exactly new here, having campaigned extensively during the Lok Sabha elections of 2024 that gave him a lead of 22,000 votes. We also led the local body elections here by a good margin, and we find the going good into the Assembly as well,” said Aravind.

Alleged mastermind of Malda violence arrested; political blame game intensifies in West Bengal

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Mofakkerul Islam, the alleged mastermind behind the Malda violence in which judicial officials were held hostage and attacked, was arrested by the West Bengal police on Friday.

The police have so far arrested 35 persons, including Islam, an advocate by profession, for leading protests that led to the gherao and attack on seven judicial officers at Mothabari in Malda district during the SIR drive.

Islam contested the 2021 Assembly polls as a candidate of the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM).

A 24-member team of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) visited Mothabari and Kaliachak police stations to probe the gherao of judicial officers by locals protesting over the deletion of names in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise of electoral rolls before the Assembly elections.



IN CUSTODY. AIMIM leader Mofakkerul Islam, who was arrested by the West Bengal police on Friday

Political blame game has intensified over the shocking incident, which drew criticism from the Supreme Court.

SC SEEKS RESPONSE
The court, on Thursday, termed it deplorable and sought response from the State Home Secretary, the DGP and other officials for their inaction.

After the arrest of Islam from Bagdogra airport, Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee blamed the BJP, the AIMIM and Indian Secular Front for engineering the unrest. Addressing a rally at

Harirampur in Dakshin Dinajpur district, Banerjee alleged that the BJP “borrowed” Islam from the AIMIM and used him to foment trouble.

“Regarding the incident in Malda’s Mothabari, whoever did it has been caught red-handed by our CID. It wasn’t the local police. They were trying to escape through Bagdogra. They came from Mumbai. The BJP brought that AIMIM/ISF group from Mumbai. Congress has also provided instigation,” she said. “They are using this opportunity to provoke the minorities and then torture them using the NIA, CBI and

ED. Outsiders are coming from Gujarat by bus. I have voice records,” she added.

The BJP accused the Trinamool Congress of instigating the mob to gherao the judicial officials and attack them.

‘CLOSE TO TMC’
The party also alleged that Islam is close to Trinamool, sharing a series of pictures showing him on posters and on stage with Banerjee. “Afraid of losing the elections following the deletion of names of bogus voters, the TMC has mobilised jihadi elements in the district and orchestrated this unconstitutional, illegal agitation, keeping judicial officers, magistrates, including women, confined in the extreme heat, humid conditions for hours,” said BJP State spokesperson Debajit Sarkar.

Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury also criticised the TMC for the violence, alleging that only its leaders and workers could gherao judicial officers in West Bengal.

Congress names 27 candidates for Tamil Nadu polls

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The Congress has released its list of 27 candidates for the Tamil Nadu elections, fielding State President K Selvaperunthagai from the reserved Sriperumbudur constituency.

Of the total 28 seats the party is contesting as part of the DMK-led alliance, it is yet to name the candidate in Melur.

Former Member of Parliament A Chella Kumar has been nominated from Krishnagiri. The party retained JMH Aassan Maulana from Velachery in Chennai.

In a notable pick, the Congress fielded GKM Tamil Kumaran in Pennagaram. He is a film producer and head of Lyca Productions and son of GK Mani, associated with the faction led by S Ramdoss.

In Karaikudi, sitting MLA S Mangudi will take on Seeman of the Naam Tamilar Katchi. In Nanguneri, sitting MLA Ruby Manoharan will face R Esakkimuthu of the AMMK.

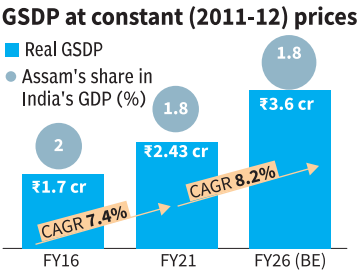
VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee, Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

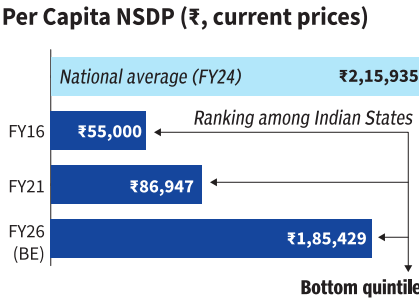
Assam's financial and social scorecard

The Bharatiya Janata Party-led NDA has been in power in Assam since 2015-16. The incumbent CM Himanta Biswa Sharma served as the Finance Minister under the leadership of Sarbananda Sonowal, who was the first BJP CM of Assam. At *businessline*, we take a look at some of the economic and social indicators to evaluate the performance of the NDA government as they seek re-election.

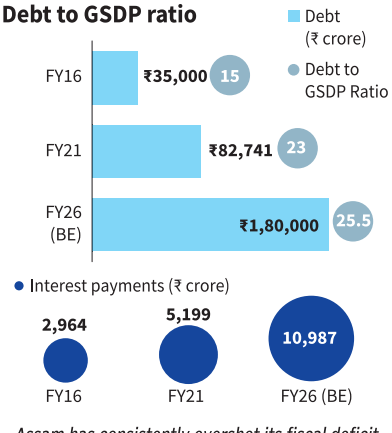
Economic performance



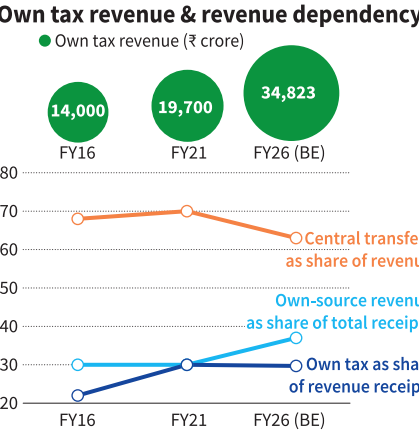
For FY26 Budget estimate nominal GSDP growth is 15% over FY25, one of the highest nationally. However high nominal growth partly reflects a low base and post-COVID recovery.



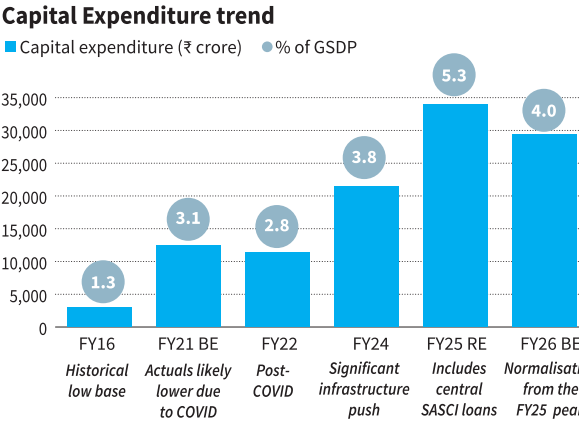
As the NITI Aayog (2025) noted, Assam's nominal per capita income is approximately 32% below the national average.



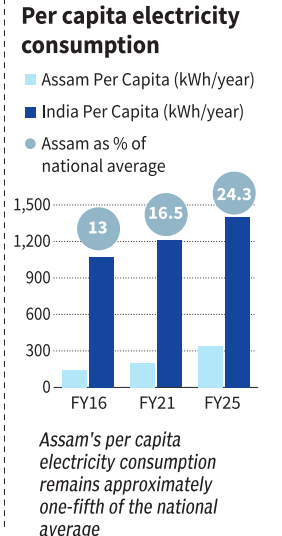
Assam has consistently overshoot its fiscal deficit Budget estimates. Actual FDs in FY22 and FY23 exceeded targets substantially. In FY25 the revised estimate of 5.7% was about 1.6 times the budget target of 3.5%.



Own-source revenue has grown from 30% to 37% of total receipts over the last decade, however, the State remains heavily dependent on Central transfers (63% of receipts), creating fiscal vulnerability.

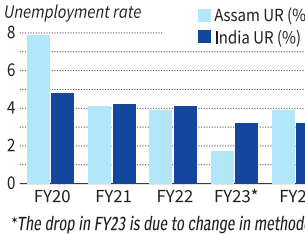


Capital expenditure grew by approximately 8 times from FY16 to FY25. The Assam Mala road network and Jal Jeevan Mission have been key drivers. However, the surge in FY25 is partly driven by 50-year interest-free central capex loans (SASCI), which are off-budget borrowings



Social performance

Following the dip in FY23, Assam's unemployment rate rose to 3.9% in FY24



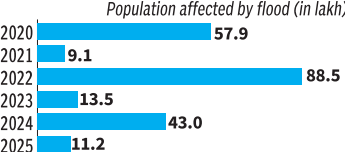
Lower wages and limited GDP share highlight migration pressures

Indicators	Assam	India
Total migrant workers	1.2 million	150 million
Migrant contribution to state GDP	2%	10%
Avg monthly wage (migrant worker)	₹15,200	₹22,400
Avg monthly wage (local worker)	₹19,000.00	₹28,000

Slower population growth and steady health gains in Assam

Indicators	2011-15	2021-25
Population growth rate (%)	12.2	9.3
Infant mortality rate (per 1,000 live births)	51.4	41.5
Life expectancy of males	63.51	67.01
Life expectancy of females	66.22	69.72

Recurring floods continue to disrupt lakhs in Assam



Source: PIB, NFHS-5, Assam Economic Survey, MoSPI, DES Assam, PRS Legislative Research, NITI Aayog Macro-Fiscal Assam (2025)

Knotty regulations

Minimum float rules need to be less complex

After earlier setting an impractical, high bar on the public float to be maintained by listed companies, Indian regulators have been steadily watering down these requirements in recent years. In 1993, the Securities Contracts Regulations Rules (SCRR) were amended to drastically slash the minimum public shareholding requirement from 60 per cent to 25 per cent; later specific exemptions were carved out for IT companies and public sector undertakings.



The Finance Ministry has now proposed a new set of relaxations for larger companies looking to launch Initial Public Offers (IPOs) as the size of companies seeking to tap public markets has scaled up manifold. While the amendments propose some welcome relaxations, the focus should also be on reducing complexity in the public holding rules. Under the new rules, companies looking to launch IPOs will be classified into six categories instead of four, based on the size of their post-issue equity. Companies with post-issue market cap of ₹1 lakh crore or ₹5 lakh crore can now go public by diluting just 2.75 per cent or 1 per cent respectively of their capital, against the current norm of 5 per cent, while companies below ₹1,600 crore need to dilute 25 per cent in their IPO itself. One key problem with low float is that it exposes a stock to manipulation. The risk of this is less in large companies as they have a large number of outstanding shares. Therefore, the latest relaxation makes sense. However, instead of carving out many categories, it would be simpler to do away with IPO dilution norms altogether and replace them with a minimum number of outstanding shares — say, a million — to list in the markets. This is the practice in markets such as the US.

The new rules also grant large issuers a much longer timeline to get to the mandated 25 per cent public shareholding. Against the deadline of five years for others, companies with market cap of over ₹1 lakh crore and a public holding of less than 15 per cent at listing, will get 10 years to attain 25 per cent float. The argument for offering such a liberal timeline seems to be that Indian markets do not have the depth or breadth to absorb share sales from large issuers. This seems to be an overkill. If the size of companies launching IPOs has scaled up in the last decade, so has the buying power of domestic institutions such as mutual funds and pension funds.

Policymakers need to note that ensuring sufficient liquidity in listed stocks is only one of the objectives of the minimum public shareholding norms. The other equally important objective is better corporate governance. To ensure good governance, non-promoter shareholders need sufficient voting rights to overturn promoter decisions. This will be impeded if large companies take a decade to get to a 25 per cent public holding. The onus for enforcing compliance will now rest with the stock exchanges. Given their chequered track record in acting as frontline regulators, this too may need a rethink.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



Time to push for rupee internationalisation

Higher use of rupee in cross-border payments will create demand and prevent a one-way downward spiral

POINT BLANK.



LOKESHWARRI SK

The ongoing crisis in the rupee, with the Indian currency edging near the 95-mark against the dollar, underlines the need for creating more demand for rupee outside India. The good news is that the usage of rupee for settling foreign trade has begun in a small way, in the last four years.

The removal of Russia from the international trade messaging platform, SWIFT, following the invasion on Ukraine in 2022 has brought about a sea change in the way policy makers approach their foreign currency reserves and international payments. Serious efforts are now underway to devise alternative platforms and channels for cross-border payments, diversify reserves away from dollar and to settle bilateral trade in local currencies. The US-Israel-Iran conflict is likely to give further impetus to this move as countries will now have to also sew up deals to ensure energy security, besides continuing to reduce their reliance on the dollar.

Rupee internationalisation, which was a pie in the sky until a few years ago, seems a possibility now, given the increasing discontent against the dollar and the policies of the US administration in recent years. This is closely aligned with increasing de-dollarisation or reduction in dollar dominance in global reserves and payments.

POLICY MOVES

Policy makers across the globe received a jolt when Russia was ostracised from global payment ecosystem in 2022. The RBI too began initiating steps to

increase international use of rupee around this time. It allowed invoicing and settlement of foreign trade in rupee in July 2022. With India defying the sanction against Russian exports, India's trade with Russia, including the purchase of Russian crude and defence supplies have been settled in rupee since 2022.

India has also entered into bilateral agreements with countries such as the UAE, Indonesia and Maldives for settlement of bilateral trade in local currencies. In December 2023, regulations were relaxed further to allow cross-border settlement with all trading partners in local currencies and rupee.

These moves have begun showing results. RBI data show that as of January 2026, 6.18 per cent of total exports of goods and services of India between April and January FY26 was invoiced in rupee, which was valued at ₹2.64 lakh crore. This share had been fluctuating around 5.80 to 5.9 per cent since FY24. Share of rupee invoicing in total imports is 4.69 per cent.

Share of rupee in settlement of Indian goods and services trade is however lower. The share of rupee in settlement of exports was only 2.76 per cent this fiscal year, while share in imports was 2.32 per cent. The gap implies presence of intent, which needs to be closed soon.

It is comforting to note that all countries are in the same boat, as far as need to reduce dependency on dollar

Rupee internationalisation, which was a pie in the sky until a few years ago, seems a possibility now, given the increasing discontent against the dollar and the policies of the US administration in recent years

goes. As on February 2025, permission had been given by the RBI to open 156 special rupee Vostro accounts by 123 foreign banks from 30 trading partner countries. Around 26 Indian banks are involved in this.

With resentment over the US' high-handedness growing following the West Asia conflict, the time is now right to push for greater usage of rupee in bilateral trades.

DOLLAR DOMINANCE WANES

Dollar's dominance, on the other hand, has been steadily waning in recent years. Unbridled currency printing by the Federal Reserve to fight the global financial crisis and then the Covid pandemic has debased the dollar, making countries look for alternatives in reliable reserve currency.

According to IMF's COFER (currency composition of official foreign exchange reserves) data, percentage of global foreign exchange reserves held in US dollars has declined from 64 per cent in 2017 to 56.7 per cent by the fourth quarter of 2025.

But the interesting part is that share of other currencies in global reserves has moved from 2.5 per cent to 6.13 per cent in this period, indicating a move towards non-traditional reserve currencies. Gold, the other safe-haven, is also emerging as a competitor to the dollar. Share of gold in global reserves more than double from 10 per cent in 2015 to 23 per cent now.

Share of US treasury securities held by foreign countries is also moving lower. According to the US Federal Reserve, around \$9 trillion or 32 per cent of US treasury securities is currently held by foreign investors. This is down from almost 50 per cent holding of overseas investors in 2014.

The role of dollar as a reference currency for settling foreign trade between third party currency increases its share in global trade invoicing. The US Federal Reserve notes that according

to data collected from the SWIFT platform, the dollar's share of international payments (both trade and remittances) is about 50 percent currently.

ALTERNATE MECHANISMS

But increasing settlement of bilateral trade in local currencies can help speed the move away from dollar. This can be aided by creating alternative settlement and messaging platform for international trade. With the SWIFT platform, governed by the Bank of Belgium, the US Federal Reserve and the European Central Bank, handling most of global payments from the US and Europe, any country evicted from the platform would come up against a wall in processing international transactions.

The BRICS Pay, which is being designed as a cross-border financial messaging system for the BRICS countries with their national currencies, is an alternative. But dominance of China in this system could be an issue. The larger BRICS countries including China and Russia are meanwhile developing their own messaging platforms, the CIPS (cross-border interbank messaging system) and SPFS (system for transfer of financial messages) respectively. Interoperability between these platforms could be one way to develop a larger alternative to SWIFT.

Central Bank Digital Currencies being developed by almost all countries can also provide a viable channel for cross-border trade settlement. According to Atlantic Council, there are currently 13 cross-border wholesale CBDC projects including Project mBridge which connects banks in China, Thailand, the UAE, Hong Kong, and Saudi Arabia.

While these are small steps, it is best to keep up the effort to internationalise the rupee, especially now when the global sentiment is tilted against the dollar.

Is awarding Trump a Nobel the best bet for peace?

The Prize is often given for nudging conflicting parties towards peace, rather than on the basis of concrete achievements

Atanu Biswas

This January, Donald Trump told Norway's prime minister he no longer needed to think "purely of peace" after failing to win the Nobel Peace Prize. Is the same attitude being reflected in attacking Iran?

After capturing Venezuelan President Maduro, the world undoubtedly understands that Trump is capable of doing anything. And besides Greenland, places like Canada, the Panama Canal, Cuba, and Mexico still exist on the world map. So, could awarding a Nobel Peace Prize serve as a strategic move to limit Trump's actions?

Trump's eagerness to get the Nobel Prize — perhaps to match his legacy with Obama's — is never a secret. Yes, Obama's nomination — after only a few days of becoming president — was highly criticised, as his achievement for "peace" was unclear. Obama himself put some distance between himself and the award, saying he viewed it "a recognition of the role of American leadership" in the world and vowed to accept it "as a call to action."

The Nobel Peace Prize is often awarded not solely for the final, absolute achievement of peace but rather has frequently been utilised as a strategic

lever — to offer encouragement, frequently acting as a "nudge" to persevere in challenging circumstances; to exert pressure; and even to take a gamble on the future.

Take some examples. Menachem Begin and Anwar Sadat were awarded the Nobel Prize in 1978 following the Camp David Accords, yet prior to a comprehensive resolution of the Arab-Israeli conflict. The Nobel panel explicitly framed this as an endeavour to reinforce a fragile peace process.

When Lech Walesa was awarded the Nobel in 1983, Poland remained under military rule, and the Solidarity movement had been suppressed. Thus, the award served as a signal of international support for a desired democratic future. Aung San Suu Kyi was awarded in 1991 while she was under house arrest and no democratic transition had yet been achieved in Myanmar. Consequently, it served as a symbolic and forward-looking award.

When Nelson Mandela and FW de Klerk were awarded the Nobel in 1993, apartheid had indeed been officially dismantled; however, South Africa's transition remained highly precarious. Thus, the clear objective was to encourage the continuation of negotiations and to deter the disruptors. Yitzhak Rabin, Shimon Peres, and



TRUMP. Nobel questVIA REUTERS

Yasser Arafat were awarded it in 1994 — during the Oslo peace process, rather than after a final settlement. The award was, therefore, viewed as an effort to bring various parties together at the negotiating table and to bolster the moderate leaders on all sides.

Juan Manuel Santos was awarded in 2016, shortly after the Colombian public had narrowly rejected — via a referendum — a peace accord with the guerrilla organisation FARC. The Nobel panel stated that it was bestowed to encourage continuation of the peace process.

PROSPECTS FOR PEACE

Thus, it's evident that the Nobel Committee often seems to believe that

by empowering an individual through an award "now" — rather than waiting — the prospects for future peace are significantly enhanced. Consequently, ceasefires are frequently recognised — even before the war has ended. Similarly, moderate forces are often honoured before extremists have the chance to regain their strength.

Some of these endeavours do indeed meet with success — such as the award conferred upon Mandela and de Klerk. It's frequently cited as a prime example of a visionary award fulfilling its intended purpose. The award given to Begin and Sadat also proved quite successful; the 1979 Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty remains one of the most enduring agreements in that region. The award to Santos also proved remarkably effective. Santos pressed ahead, and a revised treaty was subsequently ratified.

The outcomes of some forward looking prizes have been mixed or ambiguous, though. Certain peace initiatives — such as awarding Arafat or Suu Kyi — have ended in failure. Yet, overall, awarding Trump a Nobel Prize might not be a bad "bet" for peace. Although there's no guarantee that such an endeavour would actually succeed.

The writer is Professor of Statistics, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

UDAN 2.0

The UDAN initiative has drawn flak from some quarters, although it remains a bold attempt to redefine regional connectivity. It seeks not only to link cities but to redraw India's economic geography by bringing smaller towns into the national flow of commerce, tourism, and opportunity. Yet, the gap between intent and outcome is evident. While new routes have opened, passenger demand remains uneven and often fragile. The core dilemma persists: can infrastructure create demand, or must demand precede infrastructure?

Viability Gap Funding has enabled launch, but prolonged dependence may strain fiscal efficiency. Still, UDAN is best seen as a formative experiment. Its future rests on whether connectivity matures into consistent economic activity, or remains an aspiration suspended, quite literally, up in the air.
Vijay Singh Adhikari
Nainital, Uttarakhand

Apropos "Up in the air" (April 3), the renewed push for Udan is welcome, but concerns about long-term viability remain valid. Connectivity should not come at the cost of repeated route failures and

idle infrastructure. The focus must shift from expansion to consolidation. Careful route selection based on realistic demand, periodic performance audits, and strict entry-exit criteria are essential. In addition, better coordination with rail and road networks can help optimise passenger loads. A stable policy framework and investment in skilled manpower will ensure that regional connectivity becomes both accessible and sustainable.
A Myilsami
Coimbatore

The Iran quagmire

This refers to "Still no endgame in

sight" (April 3). Impelled by Israel Prime Minister, the US President began a war with Iran to destroy its nuclear arsenal and ensure world peace. Today he himself looks like a real risk to world peace. Trump has little domestic support for the Iran war. NATO member nations are keeping aloof. Doubts are being raised about his war strategy. Iran has cleverly devised a powerful tool — selective closing of strait of Hormuz. The economic effects of Trump's actions have left the world in a much worse condition already. Let us hope the pressure of the world opinion for diplomacy will

supersede his claim of valour.

YG Chouksey
Pune

Healthcare personnel

The article 'Allied healthcare needs attention' (April 3) made interesting reading. It is imperative that India plans its resources (material and human) well in the healthcare sector. That it faces a shortage of more than eight million healthcare workers today smacks of its poor manpower planning. With a billion plus population, there would not be shortage of labour in any sector.
S Ramakrishnasayee
Chennai

QUICKLY.

Cryptos trims losses as conflict tensions ease

New Delhi: Bitcoin and Ether trimmed recent losses and stabilised this week as improving sentiment around a potential de-escalation in the Iran conflict boosted risk appetite, though trading remained subdued. Bitcoin hovered in a narrow \$66,000-\$67,000 range with declining volumes, signalling investor hesitation, while altcoins underperformed amid the leading cryptocurrency's continued dominance, according to WazirX. Precious metals saw sharp corrections after earlier gains, indicating profit-booking. [PTI](#)

PNB officers flag transfer of scale IV officers

New Delhi: The PNB officers union has written to the bank's Managing Director to reconsider the mass-scale transfer of scale IV officers and above. In a letter to bank MD and CEO Ashok Chandra, the All India Punjab National Bank Officers' Association said that 1,142 scale IV officers, nearly one-fourth of its strength, had been given transfer orders, which is creating huge disruption. [PTI](#)

SEBI readies digital platform to expand advisory base

SINGLE-WINDOW INTERFACE. Platform will ease registration and compliance

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India is likely to launch a digital platform, SEBI SETU this month to simplify registration and compliance for investment advisers (IAs) as it seeks to widen the country's limited advisory base.

The initiative comes amid a surge in retail participation, with over 22 crore demat accounts, even as the number of registered investment advisers remains below 1,000, with fewer active participants.

SETU is expected to serve as a single-window interface, guiding applicants through the registration process and helping existing advisers navigate ongoing compliance requirements — areas that have often deterred professionals from entering the regulated space, according to sources aware of the discussions.

"It essentially is aimed at making the compliance pro-



BALANCING ACT. This comes amid a surge in retail participation, with over 22 crore demat accounts, even as the number of registered IAs remains below 1,000 [REUTERS](#)

cess simpler and more navigable, especially for those who are currently outside the regulated framework," a person familiar with the development said.

SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey had earlier said the platform is being developed to provide "simple and end-to-end regulatory guidance from registration to ongoing compliance for IAs".

The move follows a series of regulatory relaxations introduced over the past year to ease entry and reduce

compliance burden for advisers and research analysts.

EASY TRANSITION

Among the changes, advisers can share past performance data with clients through one-to-one communication using standardised templates vetted by professionals from the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India or the Institute of Cost Accountants of India.

This will be allowed for two years after the operationalisation of the Past Risk and Return Verification

BuzzBallz clocks 3x monthly growth in Bengaluru

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

US-based ready-to-drink (RTD) brand BuzzBallz is seeing rapid early traction in India, clocking nearly three-fold month-on-month (m-o-m) growth in Bengaluru since its December launch.

BuzzBallz has also secured distribution in 30 per cent of Bengaluru's RTD outlet universe and has captured 20 per cent market share in the city within the RTD segment in the launched stores as of February.

Jess Scheerhorn, President of BuzzBallz, said that in Bengaluru, the brand is now available in around 700 retail outlets.

Riding this momentum, BuzzBallz is also preparing to expand into Maharashtra and Goa by August. These two key markets together account for roughly 25 per cent of RTD industry volumes across India.

"When we visited Maharashtra, including Pune and Mumbai, we observed clear customer interest and demand. Data indicate that RTDs in India are expected



Jess Scheerhorn, President, BuzzBallz

to grow at over 6-10 per cent, which is on the higher side for category expansion. We also noticed a shift, with many consumers moving away from beer, making RTDs an increasingly pre-

ferred choice," Jess told *businessline*.

INDIAN FLAVOURS

The India portfolio includes three market-specific flavours — Berry Lemon Squeeze, Strawberry Squeeze and Chilli Guava Groove, with additional variants underway.

Jess shared, "Some of these India-inspired flavours like Chilli Guava Groove are seeing demand from the US." In India, digital engagement is emerging as a key driver of retail partnerships, she added.

JJG Aero eyes \$100 m in 5 years to scale up capacity

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Aerospace components maker JJG Aero is targeting \$100 million in revenue over the next five years, as it looks to capitalise on shifting global supply chains and scale up capacity.

To support this, the company had raised \$30 million in Series B round in January 2026, led by Norwest Venture Partners, to build a new 200,000 sq ft facility in North Bengaluru. The push comes even as global aircraft pro-

duction remains constrained by supply chain bottlenecks, creating both an opportunity and uncertainty for emerging suppliers.

The company, which operates in the commercial aircraft components space, expects to sustain a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) in the mid-30s, driven by strong demand from global original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) and tier-one suppliers.

"Our aerospace division has grown eight times in the last six years," said Anuj Jhunjhunwala, CEO, JJG



JJG Aero raised \$30 m in a Series B round in January to build a 200,000 sq ft facility in north Bengaluru

a CAGR in the mid-30s from here."

EYES ON INDIA

The growth comes amid increasing global interest in India as an alternative manufacturing base.

Jhunjhunwala pointed to labour shortages and high costs in developed markets, alongside geopolitical realignments post-Covid. He added that India's share in the global aerospace supply chain remains under 2 per cent, but has doubled over the past decade, indicating strong headroom for growth.

'IT sector set for April rebound on better earnings'

bl.interview

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Over the last couple of years, two key benchmark indices, the Nifty 50 and the Sensex, have delivered near-zero returns. In FY26, the indices plunged 5 per cent and 7 per cent, amid heightened volatility and significant foreign portfolio investor outflows. Three conflicts (Russia-Ukraine, Israel-Palestine and the West Asia war) have brought the world economy to its knees as crude oil prices went through the roof. While investor wealth has been eroded, corporate earnings are also under pressure.

In this backdrop, VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments, discussed the way forward.

Edited excerpts:

How long will it take for markets to rebound? The market rebound will depend on the duration of the conflict in West Asia.



Financials, auto & auto ancillaries, defence, capital goods, capital market-related stocks, pharma will do well

VK VIJAYAKUMAR
Chief Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments

If the war prolongs and crude prices remain above \$100 a barrel for an extended period, recovery will be delayed by months.

If the conflict escalates and crude spikes above \$120, the market will plummet. IPO market may remain subdued till the secondary market revives. Only fairly valued IPOs will get subscribed.

Will rupee depreciation impact the government's fiscal strength?

The government's fiscal strength will be impacted by the steep excise duty cuts taken after the crude price spike. A higher fiscal deficit will be inflationary.

Rupee depreciation has the potential to trigger further FPI outflows, which, in turn, will further depreciate the currency. The main concern is how to finance the rising current account deficit amid sustained FPI outflows.

What are corporate earnings expectations for FY27? Which sectors do you see as best and worst performers?

Earnings in FY27 will depend on how long the war lasts. If the war continues for, say, one more month and the crude price remains above \$100, India's macro indicators, including GDP growth, will take a hit.

In such a scenario, the pre-war estimate of around 15 per cent earnings growth will not materialise. On the other hand, if there is de-escalation or the end of the conflict, 12-14 per cent earnings growth is achievable.

Financials, automobiles and auto ancillaries, defence, capital goods, capital market-related stocks and pharmaceuticals will do well. The FMCG sector is likely to be under pressure.

Do you see consumption slowing down in the coming months?

Inflation is yet to impact consumption. Inflation was benign last year.

The government has not passed on the higher crude cost to consumers, but if crude price remains elevated for another month, at least a partial pass-through will occur. Then inflation will rise, which will impact consumption. Job losses are sporadic.

Beaten-down segments such as financials, automobiles and blue chips from across segments will benefit once the markets bounce back. IT has corrected sharply following the An-the shock. The IT sector is due for a rebound in April, following results that are unlikely to disappoint.

US-based Lockton to enter India's reinsurance space

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

US-based insurance broker Lockton is in the process of expanding into the reinsurance space in India, with a formal market entry expected in this financial year.

The world's largest independent insurance brokerage commenced operations in India on January 1, 2025.

"We are present in nine branches across the country, including major hubs such as Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata, Bengaluru and Chennai, and continue to expand our footprint in line with client demand," Sandeep Dadia, CEO & Country Head, Lockton India, told *businessline*.

From a scale perspective, the insurance broker serves



COVERING MORE GROUND. Lockton is present in India as an insurance brokerage firm, with nine branches in Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata, Bengaluru and Chennai [ISTOCKPHOTO](#)

over 1,000 clients across sectors in the country, supported by a team of 241 associates, with plans to scale this to around 380 as it continues to grow.

"This reflects both the strength of our value proposition and the increasing demand for specialised risk ad-

visory solutions," Dadia said, adding a key differentiator had been its investment in technology.

"Our reinsurance offerings will span property and marine lines, including cargo, hull, and war, alongside specialised areas such as cruise lines and protection &

indemnity (P&I)," the CEO said.

INVESTMENT PLANNED

Lockton has a significant presence in the international reinsurance market. Globally, it manages a large treaty business and is considered among the top 10 treaty brokers worldwide. It handles a substantial facultative reinsurance portfolio internationally.

"We invest heavily in analytics, geotagging, and risk assessment. The same philosophy will guide our expansion in India. Once we have sufficient capacity to serve Indian clients, we will extend treaty reinsurance offerings, ensuring that every engagement adds measurable value to the client's portfolio," Dadia said.

Flipkart-backed NeuroPixel.AI winds up as competition intensifies

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based GenAI start-up NeuroPixel.AI has shut down its service operations after five years, with CEO and Co-founder Arvind Venugopal Nair citing inability to compete with rapidly advancing image-generation models from large technology firms.

In a LinkedIn post on Thursday, Nair said, "While we got the broader thesis right (Gen-AI for Fashion) way back in 2021, we got massively outgunned overnight in late 2025. We had spent 4 years building deep IP with a small team, thinking that our competition would be other start-ups. But our product didn't hold up against the capabilities of powerful image generation models like NanoBanana Pro by Google."

Founded in 2020, NeuroPixel.AI built proprietary technology with a small team for nearly four years, expecting competition primarily from other start-ups.

However, the emergence of high-performance, largescale image models like NanoBanana Pro altered the



SLIM LIFE SPAN. The emergence of high-performance, largescale image models like NanoBanana Pro reduced the relative advantage of smaller players

market dynamics, reducing the relative advantage of smaller players.

WHAT ALL IS LEFT?

According to data from Tracxn, the company raised \$1.28 million across four equity funding rounds and was last valued at \$5.81 million in September 2022. Its backers include Anicut Capital, Inflection Point Ventures, Flipkart Ventures, Dexter Ventures, Huddle Ventures, and ISB I-Venture.

"We do still have a unique tech stack that is comparable to Google's Nanobanana Pro in terms of output quality, and at a fraction of the cost, which we are in discussions to monetise, but for all practical purposes we are shuttering service operations,"

Nair said. He added that the start-up had only a brief window of around six months where its proprietary technology offered an edge.

As the ecosystem evolved, the game increasingly depended less on core intellectual property (IP) and more on distribution strategies built on top of large foundational models.

The company's financial position was further strained after its largest client went under, leaving over six months of dues unpaid.

Despite shutting down its services, NeuroPixel.AI is exploring options to monetise its underlying technology stack, which Nair claimed delivers output quality comparable to leading models at a fraction of the cost.

QUICKLY.

Japanese rubber futures zoom to 14-month high



Tokyo: Japanese rubber futures climbed to a 14-month high on Friday, supported by a firmer Shanghai market and a rally in Tokyo equities amid hopes that Gulf oil shipments could be restored through global efforts. The Osaka Exchange rubber contract for September delivery finished 1.6 per cent higher at ¥393.7 per kg. **REUTERS**

Palm oil logs fifth straight weekly gain

Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures edged almost 1 per cent higher to log a fifth straight weekly gain, driven by expectations of lower inventories, Indonesia's biodiesel plans and heightened Middle East tensions. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the BMD gained 47 ringgit to 4,838 ringgit (\$1,201.09) a tonne. **REUTERS**

Iron ore set for 2nd weekly loss on high China stocks



Beijing: Iron ore prices extended losses to a second straight session and were set for a second weekly decline, dragged down by elevated portside stocks in top consumer China. The most-traded iron ore contract on China's Dalian Commodity Exchange closed daytime trade down 0.5 per cent at 799.5 yuan (\$116.26) a tonne. **REUTERS**

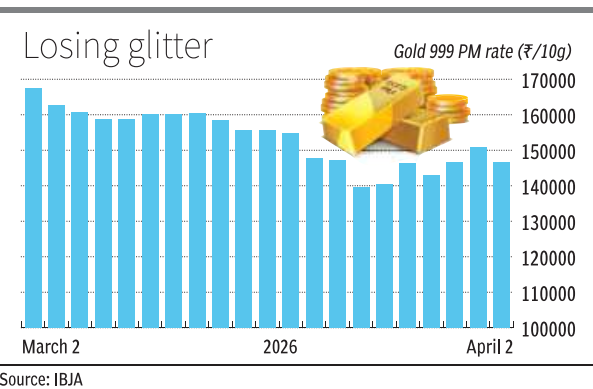
Central banks' net gold purchases up in February

MIXED TREND. National Bank of Poland buys 20 tonnes, raises its holdings to 570 tonnes, while Russia and Turkiye sell

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Gold purchases by central banks in February were led by the National Bank of Poland (NBP) and Uzbekistan but Turkiye and Russia turned sellers, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) showed. Banks were net buyers of 19 tonnes, driven largely by a 20-tonne purchase by NBP. The Polish central bank resumed buying after a lull in January. This was its highest purchase after February 2025, when it bought 29 tonnes. Marissa Salim, WGC's Senior Research Lead, APAC,

said Poland now has 31 per cent of its reserves in gold at 570 tonnes. It has targeted purchase of 700 tonnes. However, Adam Glapinski, the bank's Governor, has proposed generating \$13 billion through the potential sale of gold reserves to finance defence spending. The intention is to "generate profits and to then buy it back". **CHINA CONTINUES TO BUY** The track record of net buying maintained across some central banks with the Czech Republic reporting its 36th consecutive month of net buying. China's net purchases continued for the 16th



consecutive month, followed by Uzbekistan that has been buying for five consecutive months. Uzbekistan bought 8 tonnes of gold in February, while the Czech Republic

and Malaysia purchased 2 tonnes each. China and Cambodia bought 1 tonne each. Uzbekistan now has 407 tonnes of gold, which makes up 88 per cent of its reserves.

Basmati exporters seek relief as shipping charges surge due to West Asia conflict

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Basmati Rice Farmers and Exporters Development Forum has written to the government seeking its intervention, saying that despite multiple representations made by exporters and industry bodies to shipping lines, no meaningful response or corrective action has been taken. The plea comes as shipping charges of stranded consignments, on the high seas and ports, have multiplied. It pointed out that exporters were facing risks of contractual defaults, cancellation of orders and deterioration of cargo quality, particularly in the case of food products. In a letter to the Apeda Chairman, BFDF's Chairperson Priyanka Mittal said, "In



FREIGHT DISPUTE. The industry body said shipping lines cannot levy charges for delays caused by their own actions or external geopolitical factors

the absence of such intervention, exporters are likely to suffer significant financial losses, disruption of business operations and long-term erosion of international trade relationships, the consequences of which may extend well beyond the present crisis." She has sought "directions and/or advisory" from the government to all shipping

lines, port authorities, terminal operators and inland container depots to recognise the present situation as a *force majeure* event with effect from March 1, so that detention, demurrage and storage charges on all containers destined for affected West Asian countries are immediately waived and suspended. The exporters body said

shipping lines should be directed not to impose any 'arbitrary' or crisis-induced charges, "including but not limited to change of destination charges, manifest amendment charges or any ancillary penalties" arising out of the present situation. Mittal requested government help for "immediate release and/or return of containers" without linking to the payment of disputed charges, for which she suggested a joint task force, comprising relevant government authorities, shipping lines and exporter bodies, be set up. The industry body contends that shipping lines cannot legally impose charges for delays resulting from their own operational decisions or external geopolitical developments. She said the financial impact had been severe, particularly for MSMEs.

Maharashtra sugar output jumps 22% as 2025-26 crushing season ends

Our Bureau
Pune

Maharashtra's sugar output has surged in the 2025-26 crushing season, signalling a strong recovery on higher cane availability and improved mill performance. As of April 1, production was 988.79 lakh quintals, up sharply from 806.78 lakh quintals last season. Cane crushing rose to 1,043.17 lakh tonnes (lt) from 852.65 lt a year ago. The recovery rate was largely steady at 9.48 per cent (9.46 per cent last season), indicating that gains were driven mainly by higher volumes rather than efficiency. Western Maharashtra continues to anchor the State's sugar economy. Kolhapur division led with a recovery rate of 11.02 per cent and output of 2.32 million tonnes.



Pune division crushed 224.99 lt, reflecting strong throughput. Solapur, despite having the highest number of mills (49), reported a lower recovery of 8.6 per cent, pointing to efficiency constraints.

PRIVATE MILLS The industry structure is gradually shifting, with private mills slightly outnumbering cooperatives. Of 210 operational mills this season, 107 are privately owned and 103 are owned by co-operatives. Regional disparities persist. While western and cent-

ral regions perform strongly, eastern areas lag. Nagpur division reported a recovery of just 4.13 per cent, far below the State average, reflecting issues in cane quality and operations. Amaravati fared better on recovery but contributed marginally due to limited scale. **PRODUCTION OUTLOOK** Of the 210 mills that started operations, 187 have already ended crushing. Higher output is likely to pressure domestic prices unless offset by exports or diversion to ethanol. With the government pushing ethanol blending, part of the surplus could be redirected, helping mills manage inventories and liquidity. Industry players noted that wide regional variation in recovery rates underscored the need for better agronomic practices and technology upgrades.

'India faces fertilizer risk if Iran war prolongs' Storage in major reservoirs drops to 47%

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

A prolonged conflict between the US-Israel axis and Iran will have a far-reaching impact on the global fertilizer market, and India faces the most imminent risk, analysts say. "In our view, of the major agricultural markets, India faces the most imminent risk. The timing is particularly critical; while the current disruption falls outside peak import season for several major markets, India's fertilizer demand window is fast approaching, late March through April, with the peak phosphate production season beginning in June," said research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions. "Deprived of their natural gas supplies from Qatar, fer-

tilizer firms in India, Bangladesh and Pakistan have had to shut down production. Egypt, another important producer, has lost its gas imports from Israel and must turn to the ever-pricier LNG market," said Carnegie Endowment fellows Noah Gordon and Lucy Corthell. India termed the closure of fertilizer firms as maintenance shutdowns a month in advance since there was a shortage of LPG. **REDUCED UTILISATION** "Should the conflict extend beyond one month, we anticipate reduced fertilizer application rates. This risk is compounded by the emerging likelihood of an El Nino event, where reduced fertilizer application amid already stressed growing conditions could significantly impact yields and potentially trigger

export restrictions," said BMI. Australia's Bureau of Meteorology, in its latest update, said El Nino will likely set in before the Southern Hemisphere winter ends (August), and there are chances of the drought-bearing event emerging as early as May. The Iran war has affected shipments of crude, gas and fertilizers across the Strait of Hormuz, which accounts for 30 per cent of fertilizer and feedstock shipments. The closure of the Strait has shut in Gulf natural gas production, the feedstock for ammonia and urea. "With no strategic fertilizer reserves and no pipeline bypass for ammonia, urea prices are skyrocketing, arriving precisely at the Northern Hemisphere spring planting window," said Viewpoint Investment Partners.

BMI said India's corn planting begins in May. Corn is the most fertilizer-dependent crop, and it could be among the first to feel the impact if the war prolongs. The Carnegie Endowment fellows said the benchmark price of urea, the most widely traded fertilizer, is up about 30 per cent in the past month and the damage extends beyond nitrogen to phosphorus. "Gulf countries produce around 20 per cent of phosphate fertilizers as well as a quarter of global sulphur, which is largely an oil and gas byproduct. Fertilizer producers need sulphur (sulphuric acid, to be precise) to turn phosphate rock into a liquid that plants can absorb," they said. BMI said India accounts for 15 per cent of global fertilizer use and 80 per cent of fertilizer use in South Asia.

Our Bureau
Chennai

Storage in the country's 166 major reservoirs dropped to 47 per cent this week, even as the level in three of the five regions in the country slipped below 50 per cent of the capacity last week. Over 50 per cent of the major reservoirs continued to be half-empty as storage declined to 85.698 billion cubic metres (BCM) of the 183.565 BCM capacity, data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) showed. Per the India Meteorological Department (IMD), 35 per cent of the 725 districts in the country continued to be rain deficient since March 1. This adds to over 70 per cent of the country getting deficient or no winter rain



WATER STRESS. Reservoir storage in three regions has dipped below 50 per cent, with the southern region faring worse than a year ago

between January 1 and February 28. **TN, TELANGANA BETTER** Among the five regions, storage in the southern region was lower than last year. The level in the 47 reservoirs was 36 per cent of the 55.288 BCM capacity at 19.945

BCM. Telangana's storage at 28.67 per cent of the capacity was the lowest in the region. However, it was higher than 20 per cent a year ago. Among other States, Tamil Nadu had better storage at 43.5 per cent, while the level in Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Kerala was 41

per cent, 35 per cent and 38 per cent, respectively. The 27 reservoirs of the eastern region were filled to less than 45 per cent, with the level being 9.752 BCM of the 21.759 BCM capacity. **NORTH THE BEST** Storage in the 11 reservoirs of the northern region was almost double that a year ago at 44 per cent of the 19.836 BCM at 8.750 BCM. The 53 reservoirs in the western region had the best storage region-wise at 56 per cent of the 38.094 BCM at 21.308 BCM. In the central zone, the level in the 28 reservoirs was 53 per cent or 25.943 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity. The storage will likely drop further, though the IMD has predicted heavy rain in some parts of the country due to a western disturbance.

Hind Zinc mined metal output up 2% in 2025-26

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Hindustan Zinc Ltd's (HZL) mined metal production rose 2 per cent in 2025-26, while refined metal output dipped 0.4 per cent and silver production fell 9 per cent. The company recorded its highest-ever mined metal output at 1,114 kt, up from 1,095 kt in 2024-25, driven by higher ore production and improved grades. Fourth-quarter mined metal output rose to 315 kt from 310 kt a year earlier. **REFINED METAL** Refined metal production stood at 1,048 kt in FY26, slightly lower than 1,052 kt last year. Silver output declined 9 per cent to 627 tonnes, in line with lead production, due to lower mine inputs as per the mining sequence. In Q4, silver output was marginally lower at 176



tonnes (177 tonnes). **ZINC UP, LEAD DOWN** Refined zinc production rose 3 per cent to 851 kt (827 kt), aided by de-bottlenecking projects, commissioning of a 160 ktpa roaster and Pyro operations on zinc-lead mode. This includes output from Hindustan Zinc Alloys, its wholly owned subsidiary. Refined lead production fell 13 per cent to 197 kt (225 kt), primarily due to partial Pyro operations in lead mode in the previous period and lower plant availability.

Aquapulse raises ₹25 crore for aquaculture ecosystem

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Aquapulse, an aquaculture tech start-up, has raised ₹25 crore in an ongoing Series A round led by Nabventures Ltd, the venture capital arm of Nabard, through AgriSURE Fund as it looks to build India's first integrated aquaculture ecosystem. The funds will be deployed for expansion, followed by setting up an in-house processing facility, expanding its current farmer network from over 6,000 to over 15,000 across Odisha, Andhra Pradesh and West Bengal, and strengthening its technology stack, the company said in a statement. Aquapulse's AI-driven pre-harvest systems track water quality, disease risk and feed optimisation, helping farmers boost output quality.

Groundnut output may rise 3% in 2026-27 on higher coverage

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Groundnut production is likely to rise by three per cent during 2026-27 as a section of farmers may shift from cotton to the oilseed crop, attracted by better realisations and stable demand, according to the USDA's office in New Delhi. In its latest report, the Foreign Agriculture Service (FAS) New Delhi (Post) has projected that India's groundnut area is expected to rise by 2 per cent to around 5.7 million hectares (mh) during 2026-27, up from 5.62 mh in the previous year. Supported by the adoption of high-yielding varieties and ongoing research, particularly in Gujarat, groundnut output is projected to grow by three per cent to 7.75 million tonnes (mt), reinforcing its position as a



more remunerative alternative crop. **RISE IN CRUSHING** The Post said this shift is set to reflect in the processing trends as groundnut crushing is expected to increase by around two per cent, driven by strong demand from both the food and feed segments. The consumption of groundnuts has been rising as a household snack. Besides rising consumption for food, a projected nine per cent jump in feed use in key producing States,

such as Gujarat and Rajasthan, is underpinning this growth. As a result, groundnut meal production is forecast to rise three per cent to 1.8 mt, supported by demand for cost-effective, high-protein feed ingredients. Further, the Post said groundnut oil output is also expected to grow by four per cent, with exports likely to rise eight per cent, led by sustained demand from China. **COTTON AREA TO DIP** Groundnut production is set to rise, gaining area from cotton, with the area under the fibre crop projected to decline by around two per cent as farmers prefer to plant more profitable crops. As a result, cottonseed production is expected to fall by one per cent to 9.9 mt, with downstream impacts on cottonseed meal output, which is forecast to decline to 4 mt.

Netafim launches 5th gen AI-enabled dosing machines

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Netafim, Orbia's precision agriculture business, has launched its fifth generation AI-enabled automated Dosing 5G product range. A media statement said the new range is designed to enable optimal fertigation management through advanced AI-powered automated dosing technology, along with intuitive remote control and monitoring capabilities. The suite of updated dosing products includes FertiKit 5G, FertiOne 5G, NetaJet 5G and NetaFlex 5G. It said the Dosing 5G range by Netafim brings together advanced nutrient management technology and a simple, farmer-friendly design. **INPUT COSTS** Built for both open-field crops and protected cultivation, the system uses self-

learning AI to precisely regulate nutrient delivery. By optimising fertilizer, water and energy consumption, Dosing 5G lowers input costs and reduces operational effort, while promoting responsible farming practices. It also helps minimise nutrient run-off and groundwater contamination, supporting long-term soil and water sustainability. Quoting Vikas Sonawane, Chief Operating Officer at Netafim Irrigation India Pvt Ltd, the statement said farmers in India face rising input costs, water scarcity, inconsistent nutrient dosing and limited real-time visibility, often leading to wastage, uneven crop growth and lower profitability. "Addressing these challenges, Netafim has introduced Dosing 5G. By improving dosing accuracy and water-use efficiency, it helps enhance crop quality, strengthen farm profitability and support sustainable water management," he said.



Axis Bank Ltd. Registered Office: “Trishul”, 3rd floor, Opp. Samartheshwar Temple, New Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad – 380 006

Circle Office : SPRM Towers, No.50, Alagar Kovil Main Road, Madurai , TN - 625002.

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that the following locker hirers have availed locker facilities from our Bank.

They have failed /neglected in making payments towards the locker rentals to the Bank or not operated the locker for a considerable period. The Bank has issued several notices to the below-mentioned locker hirers requesting them to make payment towards locker rentals or operate the locker and/or close the locker facility(ies). The communication in this regard was either duly acknowledged by them and/or returned undelivered.

This is the final notice to notify that if the below-mentioned locker hirers fail to pay the arrears of locker rentals to the Bank or do not operate the locker on or before **03/07/2026**, the Bank shall break and open the locks of the locker and take inventory of any items lying in the locker. All such items will be kept in the Bank’s custody until such time the arrears of rent along with interest, expenses, charges, etc. are paid to the Bank. This will be done as per the Banking Law and Practice and at locker hirer’s risk and responsibility.

If any cash is found in the locker, the Bank reserves the right to adjust the same against the outstanding dues and it shall be treated as proper discharge on part of the Bank and no claims, whatsoever, shall be entertained thereafter in this regard. For the outstanding dues of locker rentals, the Bank reserves its right to proceed legally against the locker hirer(s) for recovery of its dues.

Sr No.	Locker no.	Name of the Locker Hirer(s)	Address	Amount due (INR)	Amount due from
Ananthangil Branch : SRP Complex, Near N.A Thevar Complex, Arunkankulam Road, Aranthangi, Dist. Pudukkottai, Tamil Nadu, 614616					
01	60	Kalisanathan R	No 32 Gangathapuram Aranthangi Pudukkottai Dt.Tamil Nadu,India.614616	10710	12-06-2020
02	4	Raja Ganesan	42 Kadappaikadu Main Road,Aranthangi,Tamil Nadu,India.614616	10710	12-06-2020
03	56	Pouzaiy	No 4/3 Madam St. Katunavadi V.Randoo Avasiyar Koll Tk Pudukkottai Dt.Aranthangi Pudukkottai Tamil Nadu,India.614618	3071.89	18-10-2024
04	77	Mohanraj C	5-34A,Kolbavayal Siletur Po,Alangudi-Tk Pudukkottai,Amman Kovil Near, Pudukkottai,Tamil Nadu,India.614622	0	24-04-2025
05	23	Shammugurajan C	No 2 J. Jeeva Street Aranthangi Pudukkottai Dt Aranthangi Pudukkottai, Tamil Nadu,India.614616	10710	24-08-2020
06	140	Syed Abudhaheer Jabrudin	50 24F Marivilan Marivilan 1 Pudukkottaiaranthangi,Pudukkottai, Tamil Nadu,India.614616	10122.5	21-08-2020
07	119	S Ramachandran	Old No 1/11 New No 1/14 Sunayakkadu Aranthangi Aranthangi, Tamil Nadu,India.614616	0	23-05-2025
08	101	Mohamed Riaz M	No 24 Samanthi Vayal Aranthangi Aranthangi Tk Pudukkottai Dist No 24 Samanthi Vayal Pudukkottai Tamil Nadu,India.614616	2086.25	20-06-2024
09	102	Arumugam Sekar	1/333-3,Sivani Nagar,Pattukkottai Road,Aranthangi Taluk,Pudukkottai, Madukkaduranthangi Pudukkottai,Tamil Nadu,India.614616	10710	12-06-2020
10	36	Muthukamathi Pandiyan	No 166 Santhipalpet Road Aranthangi, Pudukkottai,Tamil Nadu,India.614616	12792.5	23-04-2019
11	61	Haneefa Jahubair Ali	No 42 A Rajendrapuram Erukalkkottai (Po) Aranthangi (Tn) Pudukkottai, Pudukkottai,Tamil Nadu,India.614616	12792.5	30-07-2019
Bodinyakanur Branch : Arunakshi Complex, 24/2 Devaram Road,Bodinyakanur, Theni, Tamil Nadu, Pin 625582					
12	29	Vinothbhan Rajendran Rama	S/O Rajendran No 121 Karatupatti Pethai, Bodinyakanur, Bodinyakanur,Tamil Nadu,India.625513	18506.25	08-08-2019
13	24	Saravanan	127h Cross Street, M.V.S. Colony Thiruppalai 2/886-3 Madurai, Tamil Nadu,India.625014	3062.5	22-05-2024
14	30	Saravanan	2/A 10W 4Th Street V.O.C Nagar Bodinyakanur Near Ration Shop, Theni,Tamil Nadu,India.625513	15750	13-07-2020
15	38	Balakrishnan S	29/9A Lakshmanan Lane,Bodinyakanur Bodinyakanur,,Theni, Tamil Nadu,India.625513	3950.93	24-07-2024
Bypass Road, Madurai Branch : Door No 7 D, By Pass Road, Madurai, Dist. Madurai, Tamilnadu, Pin 625010					
16	48	Sakthimurugan	No 407 Suthi Block Chitra Avenue Choolaimedai,Chennai,Tamil Nadu, India.625010	32165.85	23-04-2019
17	38	Akila Y	Flat No 20 TPM Colony Near Om Sathana School Theni Main Road Viratipathu Near Om Sathana School,Madurai, Tamil Nadu,India.625016	39068.76	07-03-2019
18	104	M.K.Kanagarathinam Sivaguru K	Pandian Street Madurai, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625002	130045.5	16-04-2019
19	22	Sivaguru K	23 Panjanthan Compound Thier Kadai Sandhu Sathya Moorthy I Street Meerambalur, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625002	28694.2	23-04-2019
20	24	Sivaguru K	23 Panjanthan Compound Thier Kadai Sandhu Sathya Moorthy I Street Meerambalur, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625002	28977.5	23-04-2019
21	34	Fatima Anwar Pasha Padmanabhan V	O No 7 N No 13 Baavasa Lane Madurai Central Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625001	24110.25	24-08-2020
22	45		158/20 Madagaimadaiyar Street, Mannargudi Taluka Thiruvananthapuram, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625516	4638.72	24-04-2023
Cantonment, Tiruchirappalli II Branch : No. 90, Bharathidasan Salai, (Formerly Promenade Road), Cantonment, Tiruchirappalli, Dist. Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu 620001					
23	4011	Noormohamed Mohamed Kasim	No 97 Heepar Road, Beemangar Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu, India, 620001	0	24-04-2025
Cumbum Branch : Cumbum, Tamil Nadu, No.53, L.F. Road,Cumbum, Dist/ Theni 625516,Tamil Nadu					
24	38	Raja S R	No 59 G/29 Ranger Office Road Cumbum, Theni, Tamil Nadu, India. 625516	12562.5	03-06-2021
25	59	Senthil Kumaran V	No 23 Bharathiar Road Thilagar Nagar Karaikkudi,Nagar, Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.620027	15750	12-06-2020
26	159	Rama D	No 58E Sungalampatti Street Cumbum, Theni, Tamil Nadu, India. 625516	12792.5	15-05-2019
27	171	Kannika B	O No 72 A N No 72A Library Street C. Puthupatti, Theni, Tamil Nadu, India. 625556	12562.5	03-06-2021
28	171	Roswanabagam HJ Maideen	No 60 Madagaimadaiyar Street, Mannargudi Taluka Thiruvananthapuram, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625516	15062.5	05-10-2020
29	146	P Lakshmi	Dno 53A Kudalur St Cumbum,Theni,Tamil Nadu,India.625516	14104.51	23-04-2019
30	78	Rajameena T	No 25-6 Sociaty Street Dindigul,Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624005	18437.5	17-06-2019
31	24	S Manikandan	Old No 32/17 New No 15 Kavalasai Street,Theni,Tamil Nadu,India.625516	22324.61	13-12-2018
Dindigul Branch : Dindigul, Tamil Nadu, Spencer's Compound, Salai Road, Dindigul 624 001, Tamil Nadu					
32	48	S Dwarakanathan Sevagan	15/1 Round Road Pappu Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624005	105447.21	11-06-2020
33	46	B Shanthi	No 23-6 Sociaty Street Dindigul,Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624001	55.02	24-12-2025
35	25	K Shanmugavelu O	4/36 Near Akshaya School, Seelappatti Post,Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624005	83824.7	24-04-2024
36	1016	Navas A	149890.95	15-06-2018	
Ilanji Branch : Plot No/20 & 21, Meenatchi Nagar,,Kurtalam Madurai Road,,Ilanji 627 805, Dist/ Tirunelveli, Tamil Nadu					
37	1016	Navas A	Navas Manzi,People Nagar 79 Near Fire Station,Chinnakada P.O, Kurtalam,Ilam,India.627001	6943.5	22-02-2021
38	1016	Navas A	New Nilambal Nagar 151 Cross Athur, Tirunelveli,Tamil Nadu,India.627805	0	24-04-2025
38	1034	Gurusamy Pothukam	No 12 Coran Amman Sannathi Street Ilanji Kunnakudineer, Tirunelveli,Tamil Nadu,India.627805	0	24-04-2025
K K Nagar, Madurai Branch : Lake View Hotel, No.15, Deputy Collector Colony, 80FT, 2nd Main Road, KK Nagar, Madurai -625 020					
39	8	K S R Natarajan	Nataraja Oil Mills Pvt Limited 99/1-A Melur Main Road,Madurai, Tamil Nadu,India.625107	0	27-10-2025
Karaikudi Branch : 15.1 Shanmuguraja Road,Behind New Court, Karaikudi, Dist. Sivaganga, Tamil Nadu, Pin 630001					
40	3	RM Vallappan	No 210 Pt Rajan Road Chockkadam Mahabair,Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625002	0	24-04-2020
41	9	Shanmuganathan	S/O Canaseekaran 640 Athikaram Thirupathur Taluka Tenkasi, Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.620027	71197.48	11-06-2020
42	181	Sornavelli Kesavan	No 101 White Stone House Back Up Sivan Koll Street Kottaiyar Karaikkottaiyar,Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.620106	0	28-11-2025
43	21	R Subbiah	No 5 Sixth Main Rd Kasturba Gandhi Nagar, Chennai,Tamil Nadu,India.600020	43340.83	03-06-2021
44	77	Suganya A	No 23 Bharathiar Road Thilagar Nagar Karaikkudi,Nagar, Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.620027	24088.51	25-02-2021
45	119	Arasappan Ponnadurai Chellappan Muthu	2/261 First Main Street Navaratna Nagar, Karaikudi,Tamil Nadu,India.630001	106990.71	11-06-2020
46	89		Dno 53-6 Sociaty Street Dindigul,Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624005	0	24-06-2025
47	2	Sindura Yazhini S	Old No 9A New No 21 Kalivasanduram Street Karaikkudi,Sivaganga, Tamil Nadu,India.630002	0	25-07-2025
48	15	Renekudevi M	Old No 9A New No 21 Kalivasanduram Street Karaikkudi,Sivaganga, Tamil Nadu,India.630001	43340.83	03-06-2021
49	84	Jayalakshmi Vijayakumar	27, AR ARM Street, Karaikkudi, Sivaganga, Karaikkudi,Tamil Nadu,India.630001	0	24-04-2025
50	208	T Annabargava Ignaciammal V Sorna Valli	No 188B1 Jayilam Ilam Main Road Valluvar Nagar,Karaikkudi, Tamil Nadu,India.630001	43340.83	04-08-2021
51	263	V Sorna Valli	No 15 Periya Unjanai Unjanai Po Sivaganga Dist Devakkottai, Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.620020	22606.67	24-06-2021
52	28	Rl Senthikumar	121 Kumaran Street, Karaikkudi,Tamil Nadu,India.630001	43340.83	28-07-2021
53	128	Balaji Sundararajan	No 11 Cdgees Road Subbaramanyapuram Karaikkudi,Sivaganga, Tamil Nadu,India.620020	18561.5	19-11-2024
54	182	Abdul Rahman	No 4 Vairavan Chettiyar Street Rahmaniya Rice Mill Puduvayal, Karaikkudi,Tamil Nadu,India.630018	24212.75	24-04-2024
55	175	V Madathi	Door No 1.50Periya Unjanai Ward 1 Unjanai Post Unjanaijanai,Sivaganga, Tamil Nadu,India.630022	110200.5	11-06-2020
56	112	Bathumalai Krishnan	5879 Kilberney Cir San Jose Ca 95138 United States Of America 95138	0	24-04-2024
57	114	Bathumalai Krishnan	5879 Kilberney Cir San Jose Ca 95138 United States Of America 95138	0	24-04-2025
58	115	Bathumalai Krishnan	5879 Kilberney Cir San Jose Ca 95138 United States Of America 95138	0	24-04-2025
59	59	Jeyasankar Raju	15 Shanmugan Pillai Street Sekkilaikottai Kottai Karaikkudi Kottai Karaikkudi, Sivaganga,Tamil Nadu,India.630002	0	24-04-2025
Karur Branch : Vp Towers, No. 126, Kovai Road North, Opp. Akc Petrol Bunk, Karur 639 002, Tamil Nadu					
60	3017	Gandhinathy Palanisamy	303 Silver Lawn Kongu School Nagar Kadapalai Vennaimalai Post Karur Near Karur,Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639006	0	24-04-2025
61	7027	Rajesh Kannu S	No 2 Ananthambal Nagar 151 Cross Athur, Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639002	4207.5	24-04-2023
62	2091	Dwarakanathan	27 Valluvar Nagar 151 Lane West Govindapuram Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624001	27225	15-09-2023
63	1032	M Sankar	No 55/2-1 Karasigan Andan Koll East Karur,Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639002	12792.5	31-07-2019
64	6027	Guna R	2 Vadiganampalli, Nagamballi, Modapatti,Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639109	12562.5	24-06-2021
65	2084	M Mathankumar	B 4 Kumarasamy Apartment Nangunjam Karur Kumarasamy Apartment, Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639002	12562.5	03-06-2021
66	2069	G Tarunkumar	No 9 2 Nd Floor Sri Ramanivas Apartment 4Th Cross Annanagar, Karur, Tamil Nadu,India.639002	12562.5	03-06-2021
67	3007	S R P Sivasyam	D No 51 A Bharathi Nagar East Msk Appt Nr,Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639002	18812.5	23-04-2019
68	2081	Lawrence Oliver D	40/2 Gandhi Nagar West Opp Ays & Avr Colony China Andan Kovil Road, Karur,Tamil Nadu,India.639001	0	24-04-2025
69	3004	Karur Periasamy Senthilkumar	1-B Periyar Nagar Sengunthapuram Near TMB Atm,Karur, Tamil Nadu,India.639002	0	24-04-2025
KTC Nagar Branch : Plot No.5, Pearl Avenue, First Floor, KTC Nagar, Thuthukudi Main Road, Tirunelveli-627011					
70	43	Ummul Sabirul	A6 4Th Main Road Magarajangar Palayamkottai Tirunelveli Maharaja nagar, Tirunelveli,Tamil Nadu,India.627011	51533.31	25-06-2020
Kumbakonam Branch : T.S. No 331, Door No 33, 33-1 Nageswaran Sannathi Street, Kumbakonam - 612001					
71	254	Ramanorthy M	488 C, Bharthi Nagar, South Karaikal Road Palavathankattalai,Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu,India.612001	28397.75	05-07-2019
72	338	Periyasamy	59 Mungil Kollai Nagar Wtd 20 ,Kumbakonam,Tamil Nadu,India.612001	62090.83	23-04-2019
73	237	R Lakshminarayana	148 Saranganai East St Kumbakonam, Kumbakonam,Tamil Nadu,India.612001	52979.91	12-02-2021
74	204	Mohamed Thasim Rasul Kareem	197,Bharath Nagar,Kumbakonam ,Kumbakonam,Tamil Nadu,India.612001	79683.75	09-03-2020
75	131	Junithabasu S	2/287C Mela Street Vadakku Mangodi Vadakkumangudi Vadakkumangudi Papanasam Thanjavur Dt,Thanjavur,Tamil Nadu,India.614303	62090.83	15-05-2019

No.	Locker no.	Name of the Locker Hirer(s)	Address	Amount due (INR)	Amount due from
Labbaikudikadu Branch : MGM Building, No/6, Bilal Rafi Street,Labbaikudikadu 621108,Dist Perambalur, Tamil Nadu					
76	75	Periyasamy Pichappillai Abdulrahim Y	O No 3/71A No 3/229 South Street Thichur Po Tholudur Thittakudi TK, Cuddalore,Tamil Nadu,India.606303	0	24-04-2025
77	80		98 New No 98 East Main Road Labbaikudikadu Kunnam ,Perambalur, Tamil Nadu,India.621108	15750	11-06-2020
78	22	Mohamed Suthan Shaikh,Nameed Jayamani Kamaraj	Faq Middle East Airport Road Post Box No 12991 Near Aramex United Arab Emirates,000000	9531.79	23-08-2021
79	30		94C North Street Ramanatham Thozhudur Post Tittakudi Taluk Cuddalore, Tamil Nadu,India.606303	8541.28	02-11-2021
80	59	Madhina Banu K	28/27 East South Street Kunnam Tk Perambalur Dt Labbaikudikadu, Perambalur,Tamil Nadu,India.621108	6119.8	25-10-2023
Madurai Branch : Old Door No 39, New Door No 37, Naicker New Street, Madurai, Tamil Nadu Pin 625001					
81	121	Dwarakanathan	27 Valluvar Nagar 151 Lane West Govindapuram Dindigul,Tamil Nadu,India.624001	130045.5	23-04-2019
82	263	S Ramyaivaishali	O No 94 96 N No 116 North Andan Modas St. Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625001	0	24-04-2025
83	28	Menakshisundaram Muthusamy Venkatarishman Kuman	Po Box 55300 Dubai UAE United Arab Emirates,55320	21308.25	02-01-2020
84	275		369 Simmonsville Ave Apt 4304 02919-6081,United States Of America,02919	0	24-04-2025
85	16	M Kumam	B Top 4 Vangai Block Vasudhara Endave 84 Tpk Rd,Madurai,Tamil Nadu India.625003	32202.6	23-04-2019
86	198	M Mohammad Ibrahim	18/40 Kanjai Choppu 2Nd Lane, South Vell Street Madurai TVS Petrol Bunk,Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625001	31827.75	04-12-2018
87	38	M Vasudevan	Old No 15 Gurunathan Koll Street Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625001	67522.48	26-12-2019
88	245	Thennmozhi Menakshisundaram A V Viswanathan	11 Mahan Gandhi Road Sekkur Madurai, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625002	4789.75	24-04-2024
89	77		C-390 Kik Nagar, Madurai,Tamil Nadu,India.625020	51318.43	11-06-2020
Manachanalur Branch : D.No. 73,75, L F Road , Manachanalur, Dist.Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu, Pin 621005					
90	18	Baskaran J	Flat F1 Rigo Sathiyam Apartment No 7 Thirumunagan Street Kikkattalai, Chennai,Tamil Nadu,India.600117	8542.5	28-06-2021
Medical college Road, Nagercoil Branch : No.3-259-1, Ananthapalam, Medical College Road, Asaripallam Post, Nagercoil-629201, Tamilnadu					
91	30	Suresh Kumar Prasannaath	14 43 Ponrajans Hacker Street Neyyor Kanniyakumari,Tamil Nadu,India.629802	108371.25	08-04-2019
Vengamadu, Karur Branch : TCGV Buildings, No. 63, Salem Main Road , Vengamadu, Karur – 639 006					
92	15	Gandhinathi Devaraj	36/2Member Kandasamy Street Veludampalayampunjiyapugalar,Karur, Tamil Nadu,India.639117	15435.93	24-06-2021
Virudhunagar Branch : Door No.105-4, Kutchery Road, Virudhunagar, Tamil Nadu, Pin 626 001					
93	78	Chandraseo S	New No 130-8 Kutchery Road Virudhunagar,Tamil Nadu,India.626001	-430	24-11-2025
94	4	B Kalyan	164 Koll Road Ays Pen Padai Salai Virudhunagar,Tamil Nadu,India.626001	0	24-04-2025
Melur Branch: No.418, Trichy Main Road, Melur, Madurai – 625106, Tamilnadu					
95	26	Senthilkumar Mondichamy	48 Middle Street, Kanthapullypatti Patti, Madurai, Melur, Madurai, Tamil Nadu,India.625106	13631.23	22-09-2020
Mannargudi Branch : No.28 & 28A,Mela Raja Veedhi,Mannargudi,Dist.Tiruvannur,Tamil Nadu, Pin 614001					
96	55	Murugesan S	Alankari Street Kalanchimedu Mannargudi Mannargudi,Tiruvannur,Tamil Nadu, India.612803	12584.25	23-04-2019
97	37	S Jayakumar	No 106 Alakkottai South Street Keezhathiruppalukudi P Mannargudi Tk, Tiruvannur,Tamil Nadu,India.614018	12792.5	29-02-2020
98	33	Haridoss Sowtharajan P Ethirajisan	376 G S South Street Mannargudi,, Tiruvannur,Tamil Nadu,India.614001	1703.63	15-12-2020
99	45	Gokul Unathurai	Plot No 11 Ohm Shanthi Nagar Opposite To Rose Petal Apartment Motham Road Near Padappa Kalayana Manappa Hosur,Tamil Nadu,India.635109	0	23-05-2025
100	9		25,Mahavadamposki Street, Mannargudi Taluka, Mannargudi Vadamposki Street,Mannargudi,Tamil Nadu,India.614001	9622.5	08-12-2020
Nagercoil Branch : Thayammal Harris Towers,,No/ 42, Court Road, Nagercoil 629 001,,Kanyakumari District, Tamil Nadu					
101	24	D R Ajitha	54/67 Asaripallam Road Nagercoil Gasteeswaram Kanniyakumari Dist,	6992.03	23-04-2019
102	49	S Samnooth Annan	23 Parvathavallur Street R V Purnam Nagercoil V Purnam,Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu,India.629003	74621.25	29-07-2021
103	15	Aishwarambali S Elthiyasa Jermia	Po Box 68376, Sharjah, United Arab Emirates, 31A/B, Irutayam Bin, Manamagar Salai Nagercoil,Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu,India.629004	88877.04	10-10-2019
104	188		627203.30	62277.03	10-10-2019
105	199	Raju Thangappan S Rajesh Kanagar	76 Glenmore Circuit Scarborough, Canada,M1T224	0	24-04-2025
106	71		6/330 Sreekanar Nagar Shunmugampalayam Madurai Sreekanar Nagar, Kanyakumari,Tamil Nadu,India.629502	28283.22	27-10-2025
107	48	Zeemath Begum	1168 Haneefa Nagar K P Road Nagercoil Haneefa Nagar Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu,India.629903	140655.16	13-12-2018
108	116	Nagarajan Natesan	No 61 18 Kodithottam Cheramangalam Manavaskali Richy Po Kanyakumari Dist Nagercoil,Nagercoil,Tamil Nadu,India.629252	19647.75	03-06-2021
Oddanchatram Branch : R K Complex, No.34/14, Dindigul Main Road, Opp. To Union Office, Oddanchatram - 624619.					
109	15	Somya V	110/1 Vanji Managar, Coimbatore North,Coimbatore Sr Iramakrishna Highway -Coimbatore,Tamil Nadu,India.641020	11812.5	10-10-2019
110	19	Gopala N	S/O Nallamas 1/76 Kuthalipoli Post Kottipudi Oddanchatram, Tamil Nadu,India.624712	6187.5	20-04-2023
Palayamkottai Branch : Thiripura Arcde, No.75-A, Trivandrum Road, Palayamkottai, Tirunelveli,Dist. Tirunelveli, Tamil Nadu, Pin 627002					
111	33	John Jenkins Rajendran Rajikoti Rajikoti Selvar Rajakumar	Mac Cottage 24/4 Pillaivar Koll Street Kulavangappuram Tirunelveli, Tamil Nadu,India.627002	28397.75	26-09-2019
112	61		1291 Teachers Colony 5Th Street Meelapal Nagar Palayamkottai Tirunelveli Near Govt Engineering College Tirunelveli,Tamil Nadu,India.627007	4789.75	24-04-2024
113	61		W/O Rajaramthani A S 15 Th Street Jewbar Nagar Periyar Nagar Chennai, Chennai Jawahar Nagar-Chennai, Tamil Nadu,India.600082	0	24-04-2025
114	50	Bramma Sakthy S	Old No 26 New No 45, Ramasamy Kovil Street , Palayamkottai,Tamil Nadu, India.627002	4371.75	24-04-2025
Paramudi Branch : 12/338-T-1, Ground Floor, Prema Rayan Tower, Thiruvallur Nagar, Madurai Mandapam Road, Paramudi, Dist.Ramanathapuram, Tamil Nadu, Pin 623707					
115	68	P Duraisamy	7/855, Manjanamariyaman Nagar, Ramanathapuram, Sakkarakottai, Tamil Nadu,India.623707	17531.28	28-01-2021
116	30	G Ganarajam	1/55 Nallamas Koll Street Meelapal Nagar Palayamkottai,Tirunelveli,Tamil Nadu,India.627007	11602.68	26-10-2020
117	40	Guganthi G	No 12 322/12 322 Aringar Anna Ngr Ramanathapuram Dt, Paramudi, Tamil Nadu,India.623707	10710	11-06-2020
118	61	Preshwathan Sekkara	In Nagar Sudevanpattinai Sudevanpatti, Coimbatore Near Bus Stop, Coimbatore,Tamil Nadu,India.642006	0	24-04-2025
Perambalur Branch : No.430/2, Thirup-Perambalur Rd,Manadampallapattanam, Sangunte, Next To Pach,Perambalur 621212					
119	6	Senthil Kirubakar	1/71, Mookkallipalli Street, Puthanampatti, Musiri, Puthanampatti, Tiruchirappalli,Tamil Nadu,India.621007	8542.5	09-06-2021
120	58	M Rajathi	New No 3/465 Maniyangkuliyar Road Padalur Kunnam ,Perambalur, Tamil Nadu,India.621109	17075.75	26-10-2020
121	104	K Vijayapalan	278/121 Kalyan Nagar Thuraiyur Road Near Kvk Motors, Perambalur, Tamil Nadu,India.622212	12562.5	03-06-2021

Date : 04/04/2026

Place : Madurai

QUICKLY.

Regional carrier Fly91 to boost network to 12 cities



Mumbai: Goa-based regional carrier Fly91 on Friday announced the launch of services to Rajahmundry, Vijayawada and Hubballi, along with five new sectors, as part of its measured network expansion. The new services will commence in phases between April 10 and April 17, Fly91 said. As part of expansion, the airline said it will operate double daily flights on the Hyderabad-Rajahmundry and Hyderabad-Vijayawada routes, while the Hyderabad-Hubballi and Hubballi-Bengaluru routes will have daily flights. The airline said it will operate five weekly flights on the Hyderabad-Solapur route, besides increasing frequency on the Goa-Solapur sector to six flights per week. “We are expanding our network to 12 cities,” said Manoj Chacko, Managing Director and CEO of FLY91.

Charter firms flag ATF price hike as discriminatory, urge govt review

POLICY MEASURE. Business aircraft companies call on government to ensure fair treatment for all operators

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Business jet operators have raised concerns over the government’s move to limit aviation turbine fuel price hike only for airlines, calling it unfair, and have asked for a review of the decision.

The Business Aircraft Operators Association (BAOA) has asked Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu to examine the issue to ensure that any policy measure or pricing dispensation is applied in a fair, transparent and non-discriminatory manner across all categories of commercial air operators.

SCHEDULED AIRLINES
On Wednesday, the government limited jet fuel price hike to 25 per cent on domestic routes.

This concession is available only for scheduled airlines.



COST BURDEN. Imposing disproportionate cost burden on non-scheduled operators will not only impact regional connectivity but also hit operations of national importance

Non-scheduled operators (charter companies) and private aircraft owners will have to pay double the rates. So, while a kilolitre of jet fuel in Delhi will cost ₹1.04 lakh for a domestic airline, a charter operator will pay ₹2.07 lakh.

“Such differential treatment, in respect of the same essential input — ATF — used for comparable commercial air transport opera-

tions, raises concerns of being discriminatory in effect and outcome, particularly when both scheduled and non-scheduled operators are recognised under the same regulatory framework for public air transportation,” BAOA Managing Director Rajesh Bali said in his letter.

CRUCIAL ROLE
The association pointed out that non-scheduled opera-

tors do not serve corporates alone but are engaged in remote and inaccessible area connectivity, and support pilgrimage and tourism across the country. Besides, they are also engaged by the Home Ministry and the Defence Ministry for transport.

Imposing disproportionate cost burden on non-scheduled operators will not only impact regional connectivity but also impact operations of national importance, Bali said.

CRITICAL RELIEF
Addressing mediapersons on Wednesday, Joint Secretary (Civil Aviation Ministry) Asangba Chuba Ao said the move to limit price hike for scheduled airlines provides critical relief and ensures their operating costs on domestic routes remain manageable. He said the measure will help prevent a potential industry wide crisis.

The decision was taken

following consultations between the Civil Aviation and Petroleum Ministries.

Accordingly, state oil marketing companies have levied only a partial increase of 25 per cent on domestic routes. The balance is expected to be recovered from airlines in a staggered fashion in the coming months.

According to the International Air Transport Association, jet fuel prices in the region have increased by 130 per cent on a month-on-month basis. This is a direct consequence of the ongoing conflict in West Asia, which has disrupted the flow of oil and gas through the Strait of Hormuz.

SHORTAGE WOES
The crisis is impacting neighbouring countries, too, which are resorting to price hike or rationing. While Nepal has doubled jet fuel prices, Myanmar is reporting a shortage of stock.

BigBasket is playing catch-up in q-comm as Tata resets strategy

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Tata Group-owned BigBasket is scrambling to close the gap in India’s fast-growing quick commerce market, even as the exit of Co-founder and Chief Executive Officer Hari Menon underscores a broader strategic reset at the conglomerate’s new-age businesses.

The online grocer has been a relatively late mover in pivoting from its scheduled delivery model to instant fulfilment, allowing rivals such as Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart and Zepto to consolidate their lead.

Industry estimates suggest Blinkit alone commands nearly half the quick commerce market, with Instamart and Zepto further tightening the competitive landscape.

DELAYED TRANSITION
BigBasket’s delayed transition made it harder to win over customers who had already been onboarded by competitors offering faster delivery, deeper assortments and steep discounts.

“They were not late in grocery *per se*, but late in changing the model... and now they are playing catch-up,” said Satish Meena, Researcher at Datum Intelligence.

“A lot of customers today don’t even want to try BigBasket because they already have better options.”

The challenge is structural.

Rivals have poured billions into building dense dark store networks and funding aggressive discounting, while BigBasket faces tighter capital discipline under the Tata Group’s mandate to rein in losses.



This has limited its ability to match the scale and intensity of competition.

“The amount of money these companies are putting into discounts and infrastructure is very high, and that’s difficult for BigBasket to match given the pressure to control losses,” Meena added.

CRITICAL JUNCTURE
Menon’s exit comes at a critical juncture, with the Tata Group looking to bring in new leadership that can sharpen execution and chart a clearer path to profitability. The move is part of a wider push to recalibrate its consumer internet bets, including BigBasket and Tata 1mg, amid rising losses and intensifying competition.

However, analysts cautioned that leadership change alone may not be enough. BigBasket is still grappling with fundamental questions around customer segmentation, market positioning and capital allocation, especially as it seeks to scale its quick commerce offering BB Now.

NEXT PHASE
With rivals continuing to expand aggressively across metros and smaller cities, BigBasket’s next phase will hinge on its ability to differentiate, identify its core customer base and compete effectively without the same level of capital firepower.

‘IPL franchises being looked at as global sports properties’

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Delhi Capitals has witnessed strong double-digit growth in sponsorship revenues for the 2026 season.

The IPL franchise, which has been focusing on evolving into a sports and entertainment brand, has not only renewed key deals but also added new brands to its sponsorship roster.

Sunil Gupta, CEO, Delhi Capitals, told *businessline*, “It has been a pretty impressive season from sponsorship perspective. We have

renewed a few of our key partnerships, including a big asset, like the back of the jersey with DP World. So clearly, sponsors are looking at this as an opportunity not just for visibility but also to build long-term and meaningful relationships with Delhi Capitals. Overall, sponsorship revenues have seen a double-digit growth.”

The team’s sponsors include Hero FinCorp, All Seasons packaged drinking water, DP World and KP Group, among others.

IPL VALUATION SURGE
Analysts pointed out that the



recently announced sale transactions of Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Rajasthan Royals at hefty valuations will have a positive rub-off effect on the entire ecosystem.

“These transactions are a strong validation of how the

IPL has grown by leaps and bounds over the years and what everyone has been hoping for it to become.

“Valuations are a long-term game, and I think it’s an interesting phase for the entire league. Also, IPL franchises are now not just standalone India properties; they are being looked at as top-tier global sports properties, which is absolutely great for the entire league,” Gupta noted.

Besides the men’s team, the IPL franchise, which is co-owned by GMR Group and JSW Group, is among the five founding teams of

Delhi Capitals has reported strong double-digit growth in sponsorship revenues for the 2026 IPL season

the Women’s Premier League.

FAN ENGAGEMENT
Responding to a query on strengthening fan engagement, he said, “We don’t see ourselves as just a sports team but we are quickly

evolving into a fan-first modern day sports and entertainment brand. Fans are front and centre to everything that we have built over the last 24 months.

The DC Fan Sabha app, for instance, was launched with a clear focus on incentivising participation and deepening loyalty. So, the overall focus has been on deepening engagement through our storytelling, building an IP ecosystem and expanding our grassroots initiatives”

Recently, the IPL franchise announced the second season of its web series *DC PG by Gulati*.

Trump seeks \$1.5 trillion of US budget for military ops

Press Trust of India
Washington

US President Donald Trump has proposed boosting defence spending to \$1.5 trillion in his 2027 budget released on Friday, the largest such request in decades, reflecting his emphasis on US military investments over domestic programmes.

The sizeable increase for the Pentagon had been telegraphed by the Republican President even before the US-led war against Iran.

Trump’s plan would also reduce spending on non-defence programmes by 10 per cent by shifting some responsibilities to State and local governments.

“President Trump is committed to rebuilding our military to secure peace through strength,” the budget said.

Trump, speaking ahead of

an address to the nation this week about the Iran war, signalled the military is his priority, setting up a clash ahead in Congress. “We’re fighting wars. We can’t take care of day care,” Trump said at a private White House event on Wednesday.

BUDGET PRIORITIES
Among the budget priorities the White House called for supporting the administration’s immigration enforcement and deportation operations by eliminating refugee resettlement aid, maintaining Immigration and Customs Enforcement funds at current year levels and drawing on last year’s increases for funds to open detention facilities.

US federal balance sheets are operating in the red, running nearly \$2 trillion annual deficits and debt swelling past \$39 trillion.

Air India’s Amravati flying school to train 180 pilots annually

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Tata Group-promoted Air India is set to commence operations at its flying training organisation (FTO) in Amravati, Maharashtra, in the first quarter of FY27, industry sources told *businessline*.

Accordingly, the FTO is set to commence operations at a time when the airline is stepping up efforts to build a dedicated pilot pipeline amid an aggressive fleet expansion plan.

COCKPIT CREW
Speaking to *businessline*, sources said the facility, licensed by regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) at Belora airport will train around 180 commercial pilots annually, helping meet rising demand for cockpit crew. Besides, the

move assumes significance given the growing requirement for trained pilots in India.

ACTIVE PILOTS
As per data given to Parliament, the country will need around 30,000 pilots over the next 15-20 years, while currently there are over 25,000 active pilots holding licences issued by the DGCA. Presently, India has 10,261 airline transport pilot licence (ATPL) holders, while 12,480 pilots hold commercial pilot licences (CPL) for aeroplanes and 777 CPL holders for helicopters.

In addition, 1,477 pilots hold private pilot licences for aeroplanes and six for helicopters, according to a written reply in Parliament.

Further, sources said Air India’s training ecosystem is being developed across multiple locations.



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Notably, the Flying Training Academy is based in Amravati, while the airline has partnered with two training schools in the United States for CPL training.

Under this structure, cadet pilots will undergo basic

and intermediate training at Amravati before progressing to the airline’s Aviation Training Academy in Gurugram for advanced training and certification aligned with fleet requirements.

Type rating will be con-

The airlines has also partnered with two training schools in the US for commercial pilot licence training

ducted at Air India-affiliated approved training organisations, including upcoming simulator centres in Gurugram.

According to sources, the airline has placed an order for 34 trainer aircraft for the new flying school.

It has taken delivery of 29 new trainer aircraft from Piper Aircraft, manufactured at its Vero Beach, Florida facility, and all three Diamond DA42NG aircraft.

CUTTING DEPENDENCY
An FTO trains pilots in air-

craft operations, navigation and flight safety and typically requires access to operational airfields for flight training activities. Additionally, the Amravati FTO is expected to reduce dependence on overseas training while ensuring standardised instruction aligned with airline requirements. Beyond basic training, Air India is also expanding its advanced training capabilities.

FOR FUTURE
The airline plans to train over 5,000 pilots over the next decade at its Gurugram facility, which forms part of its broader Aviation Training Academy.

Earlier, Campbell Wilson, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Air India, had said the airline’s expansion, with 600 aircraft on order, necessitates significant investments in training infrastructure.

Artificial intelligence bolsters advertising, engagement-linked revenue: Amazon MX Player

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

In an age where all media conversations are sprinkled with AI, Karan Bedi, Director and Head of Amazon MX Player, and Amogh Dusad, Director and Head of Content, have found particular benefits of AI integration not just in production but also in the advertising stack offered to advertisers. Following the platform’s integration with Amazon in 2025, the two talk about how consumer behaviour changes alongside technological progress.

Edited excerpts:

2025 was your first year with Amazon. What were the highlights?

Bedi: We hit and exceeded all our targets on many of the metrics for 2025. On the revenue side, we spent time implementing the platform as

part of the Amazon product suite and service stack. More than 150 advertisers came on board across different categories and started taking part in the full funnel solutions that Amazon is offering. We are the only ones who can reach all the way to the end of the funnel with buying behaviour with the shopping signals provided by Amazon Shopping. So, there was major acceptance from top advertisers all the way down to SMEs and beyond across all agencies.

Dusad: We launched more than 150 shows. We are seeing diversity not only in genres but also formats in the consumer landscape. The same consumer is looking for different kind of content. Even our narrative with building advertisers’ stories into our shows saw a lot of success. Our shows *Campus Beats*, *Heartbeats*, *Rise and Fall* and *Battleground* brought a lot of brands inside the content, deepening the advertiser partnership

There was major acceptance from top advertisers all the way down to SMEs and beyond, across all agencies

KARAN BEDI
Director and Head of Amazon MX Player



where we are offering a full funnel of Amazon solutions.

How did you measure the ads integration success?

Dusad: We consider the scale of partnerships. More than 25 to 30 brand integration partnerships are happening across our shows. Then we look at how brands feel about that integration. A lot of brands are coming back on our shows for the future season, like *Campus Beats* has Samsung on board, *Rise and Fall* has Amul.

How has AI played a role in terms of your content?

Dusad: We see AI use-cases across our content journey, from simple low hanging use-cases of localisation and dubbing to possibilities of getting multiple languages at much lower cost. The turnaround timelines for VFX bring products to customers much faster and we can now add shows in our portfolio which, without AI, would have made us hesitate. You will see some of those shows and parts come up in our

Revenue is linked to our ability to keep customers engaged. AI becomes a great advantage to keep them excited

AMOGH DUSAD
Director and Head of Content

2026 line-up. AI is finally a tool. It has dropped access barriers.

Do you see it contributing to your revenue in any way meaningfully?

Dusad: Revenue is linked to our ability to keep customers engaged. AI becomes a great advantage to keep them excited.

Bedi: AI is moving out massively across our entire advertising stack. There are tools available that allow advertisers to produce creat-



ives, including full video TV series, etc. So, that’s one major aspect of AI where we at MX are a big beneficiary because video is one of the main areas where this is used. Advertisers who start on Amazon and do more search advertising, etc., now have the ability to quickly create a TV series and roll it out on MX, and then create that demand pool on top and go further down the funnel to provide revenue. So, that’s one major aspect of AI that is important. On the marketing side, AI tools help get our

message out to our customers more easily and more efficiently.

Many companies are looking at short-form content. What are your expectations in terms of Fatafat?

Bedi: We’ve taken a very different view on it than most of the competitors. We launched in India, and we are going to go free. There are a bunch of other players in the market but they charge for it.

Amazon has the full funnel ability across shopping signals, the ad tech that powers all this, the scale that MX brings to the table. We have the ingredients for being able to launch an ad-driven microdrama business. Microdrama is just at the very beginning of where it can be. This model of scale with free, good quality, premium content and Amazon’s abilities in the advertising space are what will set us apart.

Has your target

audience changed in terms of geography or in terms of age?

Dusad: The part that is popping up is more on the gender. The digital universe is almost 70 per cent skewed towards male audiences.

Now, we are seeing a very strong acceptance for this content from female customers. Before, smartphone and data access were more male-skewed but as digital penetration grows you are seeing more audiences across gender and age groups coming on to digital video consumption.

What’s the game plan for 2026?

Bedi: We are doubling down further on our VDC category, which continues to be a big driver of new time for us.

We’ve got one of our flagship shows *Made in India*, with Titan, coming out soon as well. We are also rolling out games on the MX platform. Amazon Shopping will onboard MX Player as well.